

Nepali students in Delhi fear for relatives amid floods

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

I am unable to focus on my studies. My family is safe in Kathmandu, but some of my relatives live near the border of the affected area, and we are worried about them,” said Bikas, a Delhi University student from Nepal, as he continuously checked his phone for updates on the devastating flash floods back home.

The flood surged through the Bhote Koshi River, affecting Rasuwa and Dhading districts bordering Tibet. The floodwaters later spread to Nuwakot and Chitwan, damaging at least four permanent bridges and several temporary ones. While many students’ immediate families are safe in Kathmandu, they expressed concern for relatives living closer to the affected areas and relied on updates from their families. “My family lives in Kathmandu, so they are safe, but some of my relatives live near the border of the area where the flooding has occurred. They are not



exactly in the affected region, but we are still worried because the situation is uncertain,” said Suyog Bansal, a DU student from Nepal. Another student, Nitya from JNU, said her family in Kathmandu informed her that her brother’s friend is missing and they are trying to connect with him. “My brother’s friend had gone near the area that is flood-affected, and my brother told me that he’s not able to connect with him. My family in Kathmandu has been in touch with his family and updating me. We are all worried because we do not

know how the situation will develop,” she said. The students noted that being away from home made the situation more challenging, particularly as they depended on phone calls and messages for information. “Whenever there is news of a flood, the first thing I do is call my family. They tell me that everyone is fine, but it is still difficult to concentrate on studies when you know your relatives are living close to an affected area,” said Bikas. A fourth-year student mentioned that Nepali students on the DU campus had been checking on one another

and discussing the situation. “Most of us have our families in different parts of Nepal that are not affected, but many also have relatives in the impacted areas. We keep sharing updates and checking to see if everyone is safe. Even if our own families are not affected, we are naturally concerned because something like this has happened in our country, and seeing videos on social media of the flood sweeping away people gives us chills,” he said. The flash floods, triggered after an ice-rock landslide blocked a river near the Nepal-China border, have affected several districts and left nearly 826 people missing, according to Nepal’s disaster management authorities. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Thursday that two hundred and eighty-eight Indians remain missing. MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said the missing Indians included those working on hydropower projects and tourist groups. Twenty-one Indians from Tamil Nadu were rescued, he said.

Delhi Govt puts Indo-Nepal Maitri Bus Sewa on hold

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has temporarily put on hold the “Indo-Nepal Maitri Bus Sewa” for the next two days as a preventive measure due to massive flash floods, an official order said on Thursday. According to officials, road transportation has been completely shut on the National Highway, Delhi-Kathmandu Route in Nepal at present after the massive flash floods. “In view of the above, as a preventive measure, the trips scheduled for DTC



buses on August 28 Delhi to Kathmandu and Kathmandu to Delhi and likewise, trip schedule for Nepali bus on August 29 have been held-up due to massive Flash Flood in Nepal,” the Delhi

Transport Corporation order said. On Wednesday, the DTC official said it was closely monitoring the flood situation in Nepal, and added that there was no disruption in the international bus service between Delhi and Kathmandu. The buses depart Delhi at 10 am for Kathmandu, passing through Uttar Pradesh before crossing the border into Nepal at the Sonauli check-post near Gorakhpur. The DTC operates the Delhi-Kathmandu-Delhi service three days a week from the Ambedkar Stadium Terminal near Delhi Gate.

CM vows all possible help to flood-hit Nepal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday expressed solidarity with flood hit Nepal assuring full support in these difficult times and saying that every possible help would be extended to the neighbouring country. “India stands firmly with Nepal in these difficult times; a painful tragedy has hit the country. Every possible help will be extended to Nepal. I pray for safety and relief of all the residents of Nepal,” she said. “I also pray to Lord



Pashupatinath that Nepal be given the strength to overcome this hour of sorrow, and that all citi-

zens there remain safe and receive relief soon,” she added. Noting that some people

in Delhi might be distressed, with their relatives being in Nepal, Education Minister Ashish Sood said the Indian government is in talks with the Nepal Government. He further said the Government stands with people in this hour of grief. The flash floods struck parts of central Nepal on Wednesday after an ice-rock avalanche upstream blocked the Lhende tributary of the Bhote Koshi river, sending a debris-laden surge downstream. It first hit Rasuwa, near the Nepal-Tibet border, and eventually spread to other districts.

Bulldozers raze Delhi Race Club to rubble

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Demolition began at the Delhi Race Club on Thursday morning, hours after the Centre took possession of its 53-acre premises in Lutyens’ Delhi, bringing an abrupt end to horse racing at the century-old institution. The Centre took control of the property on Lok Kalyan Marg after the Patiala House Court on Tuesday dismissed the club’s plea seeking an interim stay on an eviction order issued by an estate officer on August 11 under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act. Bulldozers tore down several historic structures on the premises, including the stables, the bookmakers’ ring, the winning post, a photofinish camera and the saddling enclosure, all of which had once formed the operational heart of horse racing in Delhi, a club official said. “It was a deeply disturbing sight for anyone who has been associated with the club and racing,” a source associated with the club said. According to the club official, the facility had housed more than 250 horses. Around 200 of them have

already been reclaimed by their owners, while about 50 remain at the club premises. The club has been given time until September 14 to complete the process, and plans to relocate the remaining horses to their owners over the next one to two weeks, the official said. The club’s stables, renovated in the 1940s, had been specifically designed to protect the horses from Delhi’s harsh summer heat. “This place was built very meticulously to shield the horses from the heat and keep the stables ventilated,” the official said. The thoroughbreds housed at the club are among the finest and most expensive racehorses in the country, with values ranging between ₹3 lakh and ₹50 lakh depending on pedigree and racing record. Horse floats have been leaving the racecourse periodically, transporting the prized animals to racing centres in other parts of the country, according to sources. The legal dispute over the land dates back to March, when the Land and Development Office issued a notice directing the club to vacate the government-owned premises within 15 days, citing the requirement of the land for public purposes. The club



Debris lies scattered after the property was handed over to the Land and Development Office – Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs near the Race Course area in New Delhi on Thursday

challenged the notice before the Delhi High Court. On May 26, a division bench of the High Court set aside an earlier interim order that had stayed show-cause proceedings against the club, allowing the eviction process to move forward. On August 11, the estate officer directed the club to vacate the 53.24-acre premises within 15 days, ruling that its lease

had expired on December 31, 1994, and had not been renewed since. The Centre maintained that the original lease, executed on March 8, 1926, was temporary in nature and had remained valid only through periodic extensions until the end of 1994. It argued that the club had continued to occupy the government land without authorisation since January 1, 1995.

Raksha Bandhan rush meets rain-soaked roads as Delhi grinds to a halt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi’s roads turned into a slow crawl on Thursday, as Raksha Bandhan traffic combined with waterlogging left over from heavy rain the previous day to choke arterial stretches across the Capital. According to commuters, there was a eight kms long jams on Delhi-Jaipur highway. With families travelling across the city to celebrate the festival, markets, railway stations and residential neighbourhoods saw a sharp spike in vehicular movement through the morning and afternoon. The added festive rush came on top of roads still recovering from Wednesday’s downpour, which had left several parts of the city waterlogged. Markets in areas with traditionally high festive footfall, along with



routes leading to railway stations and bus terminals, are typically among the worst affected during Raksha Bandhan, as people travel to be with siblings, often carrying gifts and sweets bought at crowded local markets in the days leading up to the festival. The Delhi Traffic Police has issued a traffic advisory in connection with Raksha

Bandhan, warning commuters of increased passenger and vehicular movement in and around Anand Vihar ISBT, Road No 56, NH-9 and Vikas Marg on August 27 and 28. The traffic police expects a substantial rise in the movement of pedestrians, interstate buses, private vehicles, taxis, and people travelling to and from Delhi during the festival. In view of the anticipat-



ed traffic congestion, commuters have been advised to avoid Road No 56 and ISBT Anand Vihar wherever possible. Travellers have been asked to use alternate or diverted routes, including Road No 57, NH-24 and NH-9, to reach their destinations. The traffic police has advised travellers to plan their journeys in advance and keep sufficient time in

hand to account for possible delays and congestion. Commuters have also been advised to follow the directions of traffic police personnel deployed on the roads during the festive period. A massive traffic jam stretches for several kilometres near Cyber Hub as a large number of people head home ahead of Raksha Bandhan, in Gurugram.

CM Rekha, leaders across Delhi celebrate Raksha Bandhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rakhis were tied across Delhi’s political establishment on Thursday, as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta and BJP State president Harsh Malhotra each celebrated Raksha Bandhan with children, students and party workers in separate events held around the city. At the Chief Minister’s Janseva Sadan, children from different parts of Delhi tied handmade *rakhis* on the Chief Minister’s wrist, fed her sweets, and performed poems and songs for the occasion. The Chief Minister spent time speaking informally with the children, asking about their schools, families and studies, before giving them gifts and chocolates. Several children told the Chief Minister they had drawn inspiration for their handmade rakhis from her Clean Yamuna campaign. The Chief Minister encouraged their environmental awareness and asked them to contribute toward keeping the city clean. She also asked the children to take home a gift for their mothers on her behalf. During the interaction, one girl told the Chief Minister she wanted to grow up to be like her. The Chief Minister responded by blessing the child and encouraging her to focus on her studies to fulfil her dreams. At the Delhi Legislative Assembly, students from 16 schools, including Mount Abu Public School, Mahavir Senior Model School and DAV School, tied rakhis on the wrist of Speaker Vijender Gupta. Gupta told the students the rakhi symbolised more than protection, describing it as a binding promise between democratic institutions and the country’s future generations. The visit included a tour of the Assembly building, con-

structed in 1912, which earlier housed the Central Legislative Assembly before the Delhi Assembly’s re-establishment in 1993. Students received a briefing on legislative procedures and watched a short film on the institution’s history narrated by actor Anupam Kher. They were also presented with a commemorative publication titled “Ek Shatabdi Yatra,” documenting a century of legislative history, before being taken on a

returned to power in Delhi after 27 years, had introduced several welfare measures benefiting women from the general category, including free LPG cylinders during Teej, the Vidya Vahini Yojana, and the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana. Malhotra described the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana as an important step toward the economic empowerment of women in the capital. Under the scheme, eligible women are being given financial assistance of Rs 2,500 per



guided tour of the Assembly chamber. Gupta said an informed and engaged youth was essential to a healthy democracy, adding that direct exposure to democratic institutions could channel young people’s curiosity toward civic participation and public service. In a third event, women members of the Delhi BJP Mahila Morcha, led by its president Archana Gupta, tied rakhis on the wrist of Delhi BJP president and Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra, wishing him a long and healthy life. Archana Gupta said the Rekha Gupta-led BJP government, which

month, he said, calling it a measure aimed at strengthening women’s financial independence and reducing their dependence on others for household expenses. Malhotra credited the central government, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with prioritising women’s dignity, safety and self-reliance, and said the Delhi Government was building on that approach through direct financial assistance rather than electoral promises alone. He said the monthly support would help lakhs of eligible women meet their families’ essential needs.

NDMC chief applauded for apologising over waterlogging in Lutyens’ Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a rare candid admission concerning civic woes in the city, newly appointed NDMC Chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi has earned praise from the Opposition Aam Aadmi Party as well as social media users for apologising over waterlogging in Lutyens’ Delhi and promising corrective measures. Dwivedi, a 1997-batch IAS officer, is known for his pro-public administrative style in addressing public issues. Dwivedi, who took charge as the chairman of New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on August 5, said that his apology is part of public outreach and strengthening the feedback mechanism of the civic admin-

istration. This is not the first time that he has made a public apology. When he was posted in Jammu and Kashmir during the COVID pandemic, he had made a similar post on social media after people faced difficulties in returning to the state via trains. He had written about the arrival of thousands of people on trains and said the administration would try to make their journey as smooth as possible. Receiving the Lieutenant Governor’s Gold Medal for Integrity, Honesty and Meritorious Public Service, which is described as the highest honour for a civil servant in Jammu and Kashmir, reflects his administrative track record. He was part of the core team that worked on aligning

Jammu and Kashmir’s administrative framework with the Constitution and central government rules following the abrogation of Article 370. He also led the team that drafted regulations for the newly created Union Territory of Ladakh. On Tuesday, Dwivedi, in a post on X, apologised to residents living in Lutyens’ Delhi for rain-triggered waterlogging in several parts and said the civic body will strengthen its systems to deal with such situations in the future. “We are trying to bring back the trust in the system; people have lost trust in it,” Dwivedi said, stressing that public feedback was an important feature of a robust public system. The officer said that there



are a few “rotten apples” in the department, adding that these people need to understand that they are here to serve the public, and the civic body will rectify it. “We have to bring back the

sensitivity to the system so that we can follow the letter and spirit of the law to serve the public,” he added. He was appointed NDMC chairman on August 5 after a long administrative career

that has included postings in Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh and the Centre. Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj said that the NDMC chairman apologising for waterlogging is a welcome step. That is how accountability works, he said while slamming Flood & Irrigation Minister Parvesh Verma. “Minister @p_sahibsingh should learn from the NDMC officer. When social media and newspapers are full of horror stories about waterlogging in Delhi. And the Minister is patting his own back for reducing waterlogging. This misplaced arrogance is what people hate most,” he said in a post. A social media user on X said, “Gurgaon and other Indian cities, please learn.”

Another user said that those who acknowledge their shortcomings are the ones who can also fix the system. He said that otherwise, officers, instead of admitting flaws, cover them up, which makes the problem worse. An engineer by training, Dwivedi holds a B.Tech in Chemical Engineering from IIT Delhi. A direct recruit through the UPSC Civil Services Examination, he has held several key administrative positions during his career. He has also served as deputy commissioner and district magistrate in Jammu, Rajouri and Leh, giving him experience of district-level administration as well as policy-making. Terming his new assignment as “equally challeng-

ing”, Dwivedi said that NDMC will focus on public outreach, employee welfare and providing better amenities in the New Delhi area. At the Centre, Dwivedi served as additional secretary in the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT). He completed his central deputation before being repatriated to the AGMUT cadre in August this year and subsequently took charge of the NDMC. Dwivedi has also written a book, “Decode Life”, which was published in 2024. Now, in Delhi, his focus is on a very different administrative challenge: ensuring that the civic infrastructure in the NDMC area can cope with increasingly intense spells of rain and anthropogenic causes.

UP border districts on high alert as rivers swell after Nepal flood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Maharajganj /Kushinagar

The administration has sounded a high alert in Maharajganj and Kushinagar districts of Uttar Pradesh, while stepping up the monitoring of the Gandak and other water bodies downstream of rivers in Nepal, following devastating flash floods in the neighbouring country that have killed at least 177 people and left thousands missing.

The administration in Uttar Pradesh, which shares its northern borders with Nepal, has said its focus is on continuous river monitoring, alerting vulnerable villages and keeping relief-and-rescue teams ready for any possible flood situation.

The Nepal floods triggered after an ice-rock landslide blocked a river near the country's border with China. The floods have affected several districts and left at



Fishermen row a boat on the swollen River Ganga as black cloud cover the skyline, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh PTI

least 826 people missing, according to Nepal's disaster management authorities.

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal has said nearly 300 Indian tourists are among the thousands reported missing. The flash floods in the Himalayan country have caused extensive damage to bridges and roads, with several major highways blocked. In Maharajganj, senior officials, including Additional District Magistrate

Prashant Kumar, have been deployed in vulnerable riverine areas to monitor the water level and flow of the Gandak, Darjaniya, Tail Fall and other rivers and water channels receiving water from Nepal.

Officials have been asked stay alert so that relief-and-rescue operations can be launched immediately in case of a sudden rise in the water level. Villages along riverbanks and low-lying areas are being closely mon-

itored, with preparations made to evacuate residents, if required.

Kumar said the administration is fully prepared and that water levels and river flows are continuously being monitored. He appealed to people to avoid going near rivers unnecessarily, follow official advisories and not pay heed to rumours. In neighbouring Kushinagar, the administration has stepped up preparations amid rising water levels of Gandak, known locally as Narayani. District Magistrate Mahendra Singh Tanwar, accompanied by Superintendent of Police Keshav Kumar, inspected vulnerable riverside villages and the Valmikinagar barrage and urged residents to remain alert and stay away from the river and low-lying areas.

In Balrampur, a condolence meeting was held at the Samajwadi Party (SP) office to pay tribute to those killed in the Nepal disaster.

Son of IP University PRO attacked with a blade in Dwarka, no FIR registered yet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Two neighbours allegedly attacked the son of Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University's Public Relations Officer with a sharp object on Wednesday evening in Dwarka, according to a statement issued by the university's PR department. No FIR has been registered so far, despite the incident involving an alleged attempt to murder.

The victim, identified as Harshit Ranjan, is the son of Dr Nalini Ranjan, PRO of IP University, who resides in Flat No. 407 at DDA Sarvahi Apartments, located opposite the university's Dwarka campus. According to the statement, the incident began when Ranjan's daughter, Yashika Ranjan, was on a walk within the housing society on Wednesday evening. The owner of Flat No. 406, identified as Arvind Tiwari, allegedly set his pet dog on her. She managed to escape unharmed and returned home.

When Tiwari was confronted over the incident, he and his son, Ashish Tiwari, allegedly attacked Harshit Ranjan with a sharp object resembling a blade, according to the statement. The attack took place near the office of a local property dealer within the society. A PCR call was made following



the assault, and an ambulance took the injured Ranjan to Indira Gandhi Hospital nearby, according to the statement. However, the statement alleges that the local Dwarka North police station did not inform hospital authorities about the case, delaying the start of medical treatment by around two hours until senior officials were alerted.

While Ranjan's medical examination was underway at the hospital, Tiwari's brother allegedly threatened to kill

members of the PRO's family, in the presence of both the treating doctor and police personnel, according to the statement.

The Dwarka North police station has so far recorded statements from both parties involved but has not registered a formal FIR, according to the statement issued by Dr Ranjan. The incident, as described, involves allegations of attempt to murder and criminal intimidation.

The statement does not specify the current medical condition of Harshit Ranjan or the nature and severity of his injuries following the attack.

It also does not clarify whether any prior disputes existed between the two families before Wednesday's incident, or whether police have taken any other action, such as detaining the accused, apart from recording statements. Police response to the allegations made in the university's statement has not yet been obtained.

The incident has raised concerns within the university community regarding the safety of staff and their families residing near the campus, given the university PRO's official statement naming both the alleged attackers and detailing the sequence of events.

Pilot, instructor killed in training aircraft crash in Kanpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanpur

A trainee pilot and an instructor were killed on Thursday when a training aircraft crashed in Kanpur along the banks of the Ganga, a senior police official said.

The Tecnam aircraft operated by Garg Aviation took off around 11.30 am and crashed about 20 minutes later near Nathapurwa village in the Katri area. The cause of the crash was not immediately known. The civil aviation ministry said the probe agency, AAIB, will investigate the crash and a team of three officials from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) will be visiting the crash site for necessary regulatory oversight and coordination. Citing preliminary information, the ministry in a statement, said a Tecnam P2006T twin-engine aircraft, bearing registration VT-NBV, met with an accident, approximately 5 nautical miles from Kanpur Civil Airport near Ganga Barrage.



Security personnel inspect the wreckage of a four-seater, dual-engine Tecnam aircraft following a fatal crash on the outskirts of the Natthapurwa village near the Ganga Barrage in Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh PTI

"The aircraft was on a training flight in the Local Flying Area of Kanpur civil airport. There were two persons on board, a trainee pilot and an instructor. Both sustained fatal injuries in the accident," the ministry said in a state-

ment. "The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has been informed and will undertake a detailed investigation into the accident in accordance with the applicable rules. The circumstances and cause of the accident will

be determined through the investigation," it said.

Commissioner of Police Raghuraj Lal said that instructor Sachin Bhatia from Gujarat and trainee pilot Abhishek Pujari from Karnataka died in the crash.

Bhatia had around 3,000 hours of flying experience, he said. Police and fire personnel rushed to the site after the crash, cordoned off the area and secured the wreckage as evidence for investigation into the crash, the officer said. Videos from the crash site showed the aircraft reduced to a wreck, with debris scattered around the area. A seat was also seen outside the wreckage, though officials have not confirmed whether the pilots attempted to escape the plane.

Commissioner Lal, Additional Commissioners of Police Vipin Tada and Sankalp Sharma and Chief Fire Officer Deepak Sharma went to the spot following the crash.

Police said the DGCA will examine the aircraft's airworthiness, maintenance records and other technical aspects. The aircraft, which had been with Garg Aviation Ltd, Kanpur, since 2023, had no maintenance-related deficiencies, the company claimed.

288 Indians missing in Nepal flash flood: MEA

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said 73 Indian nationals working on the Trishuli One power project were among those currently uncontactable. The Indian Embassy in Kathmandu is coordinating with the project authorities to obtain information about their status. Several groups travelling for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra have also been affected. According to the MEA, two groups of 37 and 49 people from Tamil Nadu travelled through Samrat and Fly Everest travel agencies. Another group of 32 Indians from West Bengal had travelled to Timure in Rasuwa district with assistance from Samrat Travels.

The affected Indians also include 61 nationals from other states and a separate group of 33 people from Kerala.

Jaiswal said 21 Indian nationals from Tamil Nadu had already been rescued. He added that a number of pilgrims who had travelled for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra were stranded on the Chinese side and had requested assistance.

Around 200 Indians on the Tibet side have sought evacuation, according to the MEA. Of these, 95 are in Garchan and are moving towards the Nepal border, while four are in Geelong city and 13 are in Zutulpuk.

Officials stressed that the situation remains fluid, with communication and access to several flood-affected areas disrupted. Indian authorities are maintaining contact with their counterparts in both Nepal and China to coordinate rescue and evacuation operations.

India has also stepped up humanitarian assistance to Nepal, which has suffered extensive damage from the floods. More than 260 people were killed in the disaster, while bridges, roads and hydropower infrastructure were damaged or swept away.

On Thursday, India sent a second consignment of 37.5 tonnes of humanitarian assistance and disaster relief material to Nepal aboard a military transport aircraft. This followed an earlier shipment of 10 tonnes dispatched on Wednesday.

The relief consignments include temporary shelters, blankets, hygiene kits, solar lamps, medicines and food packets. Additional supplies are expected to be sent in the coming days.

Jaishankar said India was working with the Nepalese authorities on both the rescue of Indian nationals and wider relief operations.

"India remains in close and continuous touch with the Nepalese authorities," he said, adding that New Delhi would continue to support the ongoing relief efforts.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had earlier spoken to Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah and assured him of India's full support in dealing with the disaster.

Modi said India stood in solidarity with the

people of Nepal and was prepared to extend all possible humanitarian assistance. Indian teams, he said, were coordinating with Nepalese authorities on rescue and relief operations.

With rescue efforts continuing across the affected areas, the immediate focus remains on locating the 288 missing Indians, bringing those stranded on both sides of the border to safety and ensuring that additional relief reaches communities hit hardest by the floods.

Nepal flood toll rises as threats mount again

The disaster followed a massive ice-and-rock collapse in the Himalayan region that triggered a powerful flow of water, mud and debris. The resulting floods swept through settlements, causing extensive destruction in Nepal and neighbouring Tibet.

Families of missing people have gathered at hospitals and other locations as authorities work to identify recovered bodies and trace those who remain unaccounted for.

With the death toll reaching 359 and the threat posed by the rising lake still unresolved, authorities remain on high alert. Rescue, relief and search operations are continuing across the affected districts as officials work to prevent further loss of life.

A reel, 18 bullets and a murder outside Shamli...

Baliyan, who was in his early thirties, was from Bantikhara and had lived and worked in Rohtak and Sonipat. He had more than 3.6 lakh YouTube subscribers. He was known for gun-themed songs in Haryanvi, especially *Bhari Court Mein Goli Maareng Meri Jaan* (I'll shoot you right inside the courtroom, my love).

His mother demanded justice. "He never did anyone any wrong," she said. Family members said they did not know the attackers. "We weren't even at home. To this day, we still don't know who they were or how it happened," one relative said. His father, Satvir, filed the complaint that led to a murder case against four unnamed attackers. In a social media post, an account titled Bholu Shahpuri from Sonipat said that Baliyan had made a song about the 2021 Rohini court killing of gangster Jitender Mann, also known as Gogi and supported the gang's rivals. Police are treating the post as a lead, not a conclusion. Singh said investigators were checking if it was genuine and if any older dispute involving that group was linked to the Shamli shooting.

The investigation is now an inter-State operation. Shamli is close to the Haryana border. Singh said vehicle movement after the attack pointed in that direction. "We think this murder is more connected to Haryana. Our SOG and sur-

veillance team are in Haryana and in constant contact with officers there." He added that Haryana Police had shared information and that some gang-linked names had come up. Officers said the footage had helped spot two suspects, though their identities had not been publicly confirmed. "We are working on all the electronic evidence we have, and we also have some very credible inputs on which action is underway," Singh said. Police are also looking at Facebook videos where people seem to claim responsibility or talk about abuse involving the singer. "All these facts are being included in the investigation."

Putin, PM Modi to meet at SCO Summit

India is among Uzbekistan's top 10 trading partners, with bilateral trade and investments together close to \$1 billion, he said.

The two countries have wide-ranging cooperation in critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, education, information technology and healthcare.

Modi's visit to Bishkek comes as the SCO marks the 25th anniversary of its founding. India, which joined the organisation as an observer in 2005, became a full member in 2017.

The SCO's primary objective includes combating the three "evils" of terrorism, separatism and extremism, which continue to pose challenges to the region.

Nadda meets anti-reservation group...

He did not refer to their demands, nor did he elaborate on what transpired at the meeting with its representatives. The Government had not indicated earlier that a meeting with the group was scheduled.

Protesters opposed caste-based reservation and the now-stayed UGC equity regulations, with several demanding that affirmative-action benefits be linked to economic circumstances. The demonstration also drew groups such as the General Sena, Chanakya Sena and Shri Rajput Karni Sena, which has held protests in Rajasthan's Jaipur.

Reacting to the meeting, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder and convenor Abhijeet Dipke asked why Nadda didn't mention what the protest on August 21 at Jantar Mantar was for. "The country wants to know what Prime Minister Narendra Modi thinks of it," Dipke said on X. The meeting comes days after Dubey and other reservation-reform representatives met Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak in Lucknow. Pathak had promised to place their demands before the BJP's central leadership and arrange a meeting with a Union minister within 48 hours.

FMGE protest called off as NBEMS agrees to extra exam in October

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A protest by Indian foreign medical graduates was called off on Thursday after the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences agreed to conduct an additional Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE) by the end of October, sources said.

A meeting between the representatives of the protesting medical graduates and officials of the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) was held at the latter's office in Dwarka on Thursday, during which it was also agreed that from next year, FMGE would be conducted three times a year—in December/January, April/May and August/September, the sources said citing the minutes of the meeting.

FMGE is one of the manda-



tory requirements for an Indian citizen who has a medical degree from outside India to practise medicine in the country.

The protesters were represented at the meeting by the members of the Association of Indian Medical Students Association-Foreign Medical Students and Graduates (AIMSA-FMSW), during which issues faced by the medical graduates in the FMGE held in June 2026 were discussed. According to the minutes of the meeting, the NBEMS

agreed to conduct an additional FMGE for Indian foreign medical graduates by the end of October 2026.

The meeting also discussed the difficulty level of the examination.

According to the minutes, the question paper would be rationalised by increasing the number of questions in the 'low' and 'moderate' difficulty categories.

The proportion of 'low', 'moderate' and 'difficult' questions would be 30:50:20, respectively, they said.

vation, not women's reservation".

During the Budget Session on April 17, the Government faced a setback as the Constitution amendment Bill, involving delimitation, for the implementation of the women's reservation in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies was defeated in the Lower House. Of the 528 MPs who voted in the Lok Sabha, 298 voted in support, while 230 opposed it. The Bill required 352 votes for a two-thirds majority.

Former gym coach linked to DU student's murder

According to the investigators, Muskan and Imran had known each other for around one-and-a-half years. Investigators suspect Imran had been harbouring anger toward her for close to two months, believing she was talking to another man. That resentment, police believe, culminated in the attack on Wednesday.

According to police, Imran allegedly went to Muskan's home while she was alone. An argument broke out between the two, following which Imran allegedly attacked her with a knife before fleeing the scene, the police said. DCP (West) Harehsvar V Swami said Muskan's brother told police that she knew a man named Aqib, alias Imran, who lived nearby, and that the family suspected him of the crime.

Investigators are also examining the nature of the relationship between Muskan and Imran, and the events leading up to the murder. Police said the two had met at a hotel on August 20, just days before the killing.

A friend of Muskan's, identified as Aman, had earlier alleged that Imran had been pursuing her for a long time, and that her family had been informed about the alleged harassment. However, the family has not made a specific allegation against any individual beyond naming Imran as a suspect, and police say the complete motive and sequence of events are yet to be established. CCTV footage reviewed by police showed the accused entering the building at around 5.40 pm on Wednesday, according to a police source. The crime came to light after the family's house help found Muskan injured on the second floor of the building and alerted her family. A PCR call reporting the stabbing was received at Tilak Nagar police station at 7.24 pm, the DCP said.

Muskan was rushed to hospital, where doctors declared her dead on arrival. A post-mortem examination is expected to establish the exact cause and nature of her injuries.

Police have said the motive has not yet been conclusively established, and that the investigation remains ongoing. Officers are expected to record further statements from family members, friends and neighbours as they work to trace Imran and piece together the complete timeline of events leading to the murder.

2,573 outlets barred from selling petrol amid E20 quality scare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has responded to concerns about ethanol-blended petrol by stopping sales at the pump. As of August 25, petrol sales have been suspended at 2,573 retail outlets that did not meet standards, according to senior ministry sources. Of these, Indian Oil Corporation is responsible for 1,257 pumps, Hindustan Petroleum for 915, and Bharat Petroleum for 401.

If these numbers are officially confirmed, this would be the biggest freeze of public-sector petrol sales in years. This contrasts with the ministry's earlier statement this month, which said only two cases of chloride were found after testing over 2,000 samples. Later, oil companies reported four isolated cases across a network of more than 100,000 stations.

The trigger was not a laboratory press release. The issue did not start with a lab report, but with a letter. On July 28, the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers wrote to the petroleum secretary, warning that their members were seeing a "huge increase" in failures of fuel injectors, fuel pumps, and EGR valves. According to SIAM, investigations pointed to corrosion and wear



caused by high chloride levels in E20 fuel. Chloride levels in samples from vehicle tanks reached up to 500 mg/kg, while samples from retail outlets were as high as 350 mg/kg.

The letter also raised concerns about excess moisture and the risk of ethanol and petrol separating after water entered the fuel, potentially leaving vehicles stranded. SIAM specifically linked these problems to the rollout of E20. It drew it, saying some figures "needed further verification" and that media

reports had quoted it selectively. The retraction did not bury the story.

An investigation into internal testing data and emails among executives at Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors and Mahindra firms that together sell about two-thirds of India's cars, showed that private sampling across 21 states had already recorded chloride far above the Government's 3 ppm benchmark in many locations, including readings running into hundreds of ppm in Rajasthan, Delhi and Maharashtra.

Some samples also showed moisture levels well above the 3,000 ppm limit. SIAM told Reuters that the data were internal and collected by only a few automakers. Now, both the public reversal and the private findings are being considered together.

The Government has responded with new procedures, more checks, and greater transparency. To restore confidence and track water and contaminants, the ministry now requires that underground tanks be tested for water entry 8 to 12 times a day.

That regime, sources said, is under way at 88,995 dealerships. A sweeping audit prioritising older outlets has covered 84,687 stations. Field teams are checking the integrity of the tanks during rainfall. Automation systems with monitoring probes are active at 85,649 outlets; malfunctioning units are being repaired. Oil-marketing companies have conducted 7,296 sulphur tests and 1,079 chloride tests on tankers carrying ethanol, as well as 151 chloride tests on their own storage tanks.

These numbers are generally in line with what the ministry and oil companies have already reported: daily tank checks at about 87,000 to 90,000 outlets, more frequent sampling from the refinery to the pump, and a rule that any contamination results in immediate suspension.

Oil-marketing companies say that petrol from refineries contains 1 ppm or less of chloride, and ethanol from many distilleries tested at levels below 3 ppm.

They also report that most retail samples are in the 0-3 ppm range, not in the hundreds, as mentioned in the withdrawn SIAM letter. They add that inspections of underground tanks have not found any water entry so far.

The science behind the risk is clear. Ethanol attracts water. Water that used to settle harmlessly at the bottom of a tank can now mix with ethanol in the fuel. Old seals, flooding during the monsoon, coastal humidity, and chloride contamination in tanks or tankers are all weak points in the supply chain, as SIAM pointed out before withdrawing its letter. Dealers in areas with heavy rain have long warned that E20 is less forgiving of leaks than regular petrol.

What the halt of 2,573 pumps actually measures remains a political question. If those outlets were stopped for chloride, water, broken probes, failed tank integrity or paperwork, the public is entitled to a breakdown. If most are temporary closures pending repairs to automation or monsoon-proofing, the headline number overstates the contamination crisis.

Odisha: Families displaced by defence project to get rehabilitation after 4 decades

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

A total of 1,371 families will get rehabilitation 42 years after being displaced from their villages in Odisha's Ganjam district due to a defence project.

Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Saturday launched a rehabilitation and resettlement package worth ₹75.60 crore for the affected families.

In 1984, around 24 acres of land was acquired in Golabandha, a predominantly fishing village, for setting up an Army Air Defence College, but they did not receive rehabilitation, official sources said.

Majhi, at an event in Golabandha, said all displaced families will receive a one-time payment of ₹5 lakh each in their bank accounts.

Also, a colony would be established for them at Kirtipur, around 3 km from Golabandha, at ₹4.25 crore.



It will have an Anganwadi centre, streetlights, public toilets, a cyclone shelter and a jetty, he said.

The Government has sanctioned ₹2.8 crore for improving the infrastructure of the colony. Addressing the gathering, Majhi alleged that the demands of the displaced families were ignored for several years by the Congress and BJD Governments.

"However, the double-engine Government has resolved the problem of displaced families," Majhi said. The CM also distributed land and homestead 'pattas' (rights) to 96 of the 112 families affected by Cheligada Medium Irrigation Project.

MP Govt to transfer cash to 55 lakh students for uniforms amid tender row



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Around 55 lakh students studying in Government schools across Madhya Pradesh are likely to receive cash directly in their bank accounts for purchasing school uniforms during the 2026-27 academic session, following a dispute over the tender process for uniform procurement.

The decision has been taken after the uniform procurement process was halted amid allegations of irregularities and an interim stay by the Madhya Pradesh High Court. The state Government had initiated the process to procure uniforms through the Madhya Pradesh Textbook Corporation, but the tender was challenged by weaving organisations.

Students from Classes 1 to 8 in Government schools are provided two sets of uniforms or the corresponding amount by the Government. Under the existing arrangement, ₹600 is provided per student. With around 55 lakh beneficiaries, the Government transfers about ₹330 crore annually for uniforms. The practice of transferring money directly to students' accounts has been followed in recent years.

In September 2025, the Government transferred around ₹330 crore to the accounts of 55 lakh students, enabling families to purchase cloth according to their requirements and get uniforms stitched.

For the 2026-27 session, however, the School Education Department had planned to procure and

supply uniforms through the Madhya Pradesh Textbook Corporation. The process was intended to replace the earlier system under which the responsibility of uniform supply was handled through the state education system.

The tender, issued by the Madhya Pradesh Textbook Corporation on June 3, 2026, was challenged before the High Court. Three weaving organisations, including representatives of the powerloom sector, approached the court, arguing that the tender process was contrary to provisions of the Madhya Pradesh Procurement Rules, 2023.

The High Court subsequently imposed an interim stay on the procurement process. With nearly four months having passed and the uniform procurement process remaining stalled, the department has decided to revert to the direct-benefit model for the current academic session.

Officials are expected to issue formal orders regarding the transfer of the uniform amount to students' bank accounts shortly. The matter relating to the tender remains pending before the High Court.

The issue of Government school uniforms has remained contentious for several years, with questions periodically being raised over delays in supply, quality and procurement arrangements.

Earlier, the Government had also involved self-help groups in uniform preparation with the objective of providing employment to rural women.

Three judicial officers appointed judges of Himachal Pradesh HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three judicial officers were elevated to judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court on Thursday. A notification regarding their appointments was issued by the Union Ministry of Law and Justice.

Chirag Bhanu Singh, currently District & Sessions Judge, Kangra at Dharamshala, was appointed as a judge, while Bhupesh Sharma and Yogesh Jaswal were appointed as additional judges.

Additional judges are usually appointed for a



period of two years before being made judges, or what is popularly called 'permanent judges'.

Sharma is currently Registrar General of the High Court and Jaswal the District & Sessions Judge, Sirmour. Singh was appointed Additional District & Sessions Judge in 2007 and served as Deputy Advocate General for Himachal Pradesh from 2003.

JAN-DHAN FOR EVERYONE

— 12 years of Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana —

Power of the People:
Total deposit amount in Jan-Dhan accounts has reached
₹3.1+ lakh crore

Women Empowered: 56% of Jan-Dhan accounts are held by women

Financial Inclusion:
78% of Jan-Dhan accounts are in villages and small towns

Easy Access:
Today, banking facilities are within a 5 km radius in almost every village in the country

Benefit of DBT: ₹53 lakh crore directly transferred to the bank accounts of government scheme beneficiaries through Jan-Dhan – Aadhaar – Mobile (JAM)

“Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana has connected the poorest people with banking and promoted dignity and self-reliance.”
- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

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States Focus



PUNJAB GOVERNMENT EMPLOYEES HIGHEST-PAID IN COUNTRY: MANN

The employees of the Punjab Government are the highest-paid among all the Government servants in the country, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann claimed on Thursday.

"If the Centre pays ₹30,000 to ₹32,000 to an employee, the Punjab Government pays ₹50,000. It is a matter of immense pride and satisfaction that the state Government pays the highest salary to its employees, who are its backbone," Mann said here.

His statement came on a day when Punjab Government employees went on a statewide strike to press the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) regime to accept their demands, including releasing the pending dearness allowance.

More than 150 employees' bodies under the banner of Punjab Sanjha Mulazam Manch joined hands for the "maha hartal", with over three lakh employees joining the stir, affecting public services. (PTI)



RAJASTHAN GOVT COMMITTED TO PROVIDING FACILITIES TO YOUTH: CM

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma described the youth as the country's biggest asset and said on Thursday that their patience, confidence and relentless efforts would be crucial to realising the vision of a developed India.

Addressing the 'My Bharat Khelo India' dialogue programme virtually – which Prime Minister Narendra Modi also addressed – Sharma said a positive environment for sports has been created in the country under Modi's leadership. He said talent from villages is now getting opportunities to compete on national and international platforms and the Government is committed to providing opportunities and facilities to youth.

The chief minister said the "double-engine" Government in Rajasthan was working continuously to take sports to new heights. "Players are being prepared for world-class competitions through better training, modern facilities, financial security and recognition," he said. Sharma said 50 Khelo India centres were established in Rajasthan, while Centres of Excellence for athletics, archery and boxing were being developed at Sawai Mansingh Stadium. (PTI)

Bihar CM conducts aerial survey of flood-hit Nepal border areas



A view during an aerial survey being conducted by Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary, unseen, of the flood situation in border areas of Bagaha, Valmiki Nagar, Bettiah and Motihari following flash floods in neighbouring Nepal

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday conducted an aerial survey of the flood-affected areas in the state that shares a border with Nepal, where devastating flash floods claimed the lives of at least 162 people and left many untraceable a day ago.

After the aerial inspection at Valmikinagar in West Champaran district, he said Prime Minister Narendra Modi was monitoring the situation. Bihar was put on alert

as floodwaters from the neighbouring country entered the Gandak river and reached the Gandak barrage on Wednesday, prompting authorities to open all 36 gates to control the surge.

In a post on social media, Choudhary wrote, "In view of the floods in Nepal, I conducted an aerial survey of the flood situation in Bihar's border areas, including Bagaha, Valmikinagar, Bettiah, and Motihari. I also reviewed the administrative preparedness regarding the potential impact, necessary precautionary mea-

sures, safety, and relief and rescue operations."

He also directed the officials concerned to take all necessary steps with utmost promptness and preparedness.

Ensuring the safety of citizens in flood-affected areas and providing them with every possible assistance remains the highest priority of the state Government, Choudhary said.

Talking to reporters, the CM said, "With the blessings of the Almighty, things are returning to normalcy. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is monitoring the situation. The

discharge of water from the Gandak barrage has started declining. Due to fresh rainfall, the water level in the Gandak river has increased slightly, but the discharge from the barrage is still around 1 lakh cusecs."

The water discharge from the Gandak barrage at Valmikinagar declined from 1.50 lakh cusecs at 11 pm on Wednesday to 1.04 lakh cusecs on Thursday morning. "The water discharge from the Gandak barrage at Valmikinagar peaked at 1.50 lakh cusecs at 11 pm on Wednesday, after which the water level began receding," said the Water Resources Department (WRD) in a statement on Thursday.

The water level of the Gandak river, which was in spate after the flash floods in Nepal a day ago, was showing a receding trend on Thursday, bringing respite to the residents of low-lying areas in northern parts of Bihar, officials said.

The Nepal Police said that the death toll rose to 162 in the flash floods on the Bhotekoshi river that wreaked havoc across three districts of the neighbouring country on Wednesday.

The flash floods were caused after an avalanche blocked the flow of the Lhende tributary of the Bhotekoshi river and first hit Timure, near Nepal's border with China, at Rasuwagadhi.

Many from Kolkata missing



SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

A pall of gloom, had descended in parts of Kolkata, Hooghly and other areas as more than 35 people including the 32-member group continued to remain on the missing list after a devastating flash-flood hit the Nepal-Tibet border.

The pilgrims from Kolkata had left Kolkata on August 21 for Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra.

According to sources in the travel agency the travellers were at Rasuwagadhi at around 8 in the morning when the flash floods hit. "Since then we have not been able to establish contact with the members of the group," that include two travel managers. About 133 Indians, many of whom were from Bengal went missing after the mishap.

11 from Gujarat missing



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Eleven persons from Gujarat remain missing in flood-hit Nepal, with authorities establishing contact with one woman who was earlier reported untraceable but was found to be safe later, officials said on Wednesday.

The Gujarat State Emergency Operations Centre (SEOC) had earlier received information that 12 persons from the state were missing following the devastating floods in Nepal. Relatives had called SEOC and district emergency centres to share information about the people who were untraceable after the flood.

West Bengal Govt probes 60 infant deaths in three weeks

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has demanded detailed information on reported deaths of at least 60 infants in the first three weeks of August including 10 in a single day in Malda district of North Bengal.

The reports have been sought from the Malda Medical College and Hospital (MMCH) where most of the deaths occurred, Health Department sources said adding private nursing homes too have been asked to be scrutinized for any deaths in the corresponding period.

MMCH doctors said that the

deaths had occurred because of a number of reasons adding a number of deaths had been "referral cases" sent from the block level centres.

Speaking on condition of anonymity one of staff said that a preliminary report had already been sent by the Medical Superintendent adding, 16 other hospitals had also been investigated.

Bengal Health Minister Saradwath Mukherjee had been regularly visiting the hospitals including conducting surprise checks, sources said. Meanwhile, in a parallel development the Health Department had



questioned several fourth-year students of two prominent medical colleges regarding reports of an interstate blood smuggling selling racket.

Three lab technicians had also been questioned from Panskura in West Midnapore district.

Recent investigations had unmasked a blood-smuggling racket that involved selling blood from local Government hospitals to private entities and individual buyers outside Bengal.

The states where the bloods were smuggled out included Bihar, Jharkhand and even Mumbai, sources said.

Coast Guard brings 2 Chinese survivors of sunken cargo ship to Odisha, search on for missing crew

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Coast Guard ship Varad, deployed for a search and rescue operation after a Panama-flagged bulk carrier sank in the Bay of Bengal nearly a week ago, safely brought two Chinese survivors to Odisha's Paradip on Thursday, an official said.

The merchant vessel MV Ocean Winner, carrying 24 crew members – 20 Chinese, three Myanmar and one Bangladeshi – was heading to Singapore when it sank about 240 nautical miles from the Paradip coast on August 22. The Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) in Sri Vijaya Puram immediately diverted MT Aisopos, a commercial vessel that was in the vicinity, to "search for the vessel or liferafts and render assistance".



Two survivors were rescued that night.

"Indian Coast Guard ship Varad safely brought two Chinese survivors – Pan Tonglai and Chen Jianhe – to Paradip today. Rescued from a liferaft on August 22, both received medical care onboard during transit and have now been handed over to authorised company representatives in the presence

of Bureau of Immigration and local police officials," an ICG spokesperson said.

He said coordinated sea and air search operations are underway to locate the missing crew members.

MRCC, Sri Vijaya Puram, is continuously coordinating with all participating assets in the ongoing rescue efforts, the spokesperson added.

On Tuesday, the ICG said

the search and rescue efforts for the missing crew members were being "further augmented in coordination with the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre, Beijing".

Additional Coast Guard assets and merchant vessels were being deployed and coordinated to intensify the search operation, the official had said.

On August 22, the ICG deployed three of its ships for the search and rescue operation. ICG ships Varad and Anmol were deployed for the rescue efforts, while Vijit was deployed from Sri Vijaya Puram to augment the operation. MV Ocean Winner's last port of call was Paradip, and its next port of call was Singapore, the spokesperson said.

The ship was carrying iron ore from Odisha, officials had said earlier.

Sri Lankan Navy commander holds talks with Indian Navy chief, Defence Secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Commander of the Sri Lanka Navy, Vice Admiral Damian Fernando, held talks with Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan and Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, aiming to bolster maritime security cooperation and enhance training synergy between the two navies, officials said on Thursday.

Vice Admiral Fernando is on an official visit to India from August 26-29, and the visit is aimed at further strengthening bilateral maritime cooperation and enhancing navy-to-navy engagements between India and Sri Lanka.

VAdm Fernando assumed office as the 27th Commander of the Sri Lanka Navy on July 1. This is his first official visit abroad, they said. He was accorded a ceremonial guard of honour at the South Block lawn. He also paid homage to the fallen soldiers by laying a wreath at the National War Memorial on Thursday.

"He also held discussions with Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan on furthering bilateral maritime cooperation, including joint operations, capacity building, training and measures related to maritime security," a spokesperson of the Indian Navy said. As part of the visit, VAdm Fernando will travel to Kochi to visit Indian naval training establishments and headquarters of the Southern Naval Command, with a focus on enhancing training linkages and professional exchanges between the two navies, the official said.

The Sri Lanka Navy is an important and longstand-

ing maritime partner of the Indian Navy. "The visit of VAdm Damian Fernando is expected to further consolidate the longstanding and multifaceted navy-to-navy



Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh during a meeting with Sri Lanka Navy Commander Vice Admiral Damian Fernando in New Delhi

PTI

relationship between India and Sri Lanka, contributing to enhanced maritime cooperation and greater stability in the Indian Ocean Region," he added.

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BJP cites Jhooth Ki Goonj website to accuse Rahul Gandhi of misleading youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday cited a website, which claims to fact-check Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's statements during his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign, to accuse him of misleading the youth and said his "falsehoods" will now be answered with facts.

The party fielded a battery of its spokespersons to launch an all-out attack against Gandhi, saying his utterances are driven by "frustration and envy" towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi. They also described the website – titled 'Jhooth Ki Goonj' – as a "nemesis" to Gandhi's cam-

paign and shared its link on their posts on social media.

BJP MP and national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said Gandhi is the "flag-bearer of lies" and alleged that his statements are fuelled by frustration and envy towards Modi.

"No matter how much Rahul Gandhi, the flag-bearer of lies fuelled by frustration and envy towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji, continues to spread falsehoods, every lie is now being exposed through facts. The Jhooth Ki Goonj website is one by one exposing the reality of Gandhi's claims," Trivedi said in his post.

Party national media head

and chief spokesperson Anil Baluni said Gandhi's claims will now be countered with facts. "Let Rahul Gandhi keep on lying, no problem... now every lie will be answered with facts. The faster the propaganda will echo, the louder the truth will emerge in response," Baluni said.

Its national media co-in-charge and spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari said the youth have launched the website in response to Gandhi's "fake narrative".

"Tired by Rahul Gandhi's fake narrative, youth have launched the website. Slowly, youth are busting the propaganda of the Congress and its proxies," he said. Later,



addressing a press conference, Bhandari alleged that the country's youth are "troubled, irritated and angry" with Gandhi's lies. "You know, the youth of the country is so irritated and angry with the series of lies Rahul Gandhi is

spreading, that today the country's youth have launched Jhooth Ki Goonj. For all the lies Rahul Gandhi has told, in parallel to that – this I saw on the internet, some youth sent it to me – the youth of this country has

launched 'Rahul Gandhi's Jhooth Ki Goonj,'" he told reporters. Bhandari said Gandhi had made 40 claims in his last four programmes and the youth are saying all 40 are either lies or misleading.

"This makes it clear that the real youth of the country, the youth who is on the ground, who is India's youth, not the Congress PR stunt one, the real youth of India is talking about 'Jhooth Ki Goonj,'" he claimed. BJP national spokesperson Prem Shukla said the website is exposing Gandhi's claims one by one.

"Rahul Gandhi's lies answered with facts. The 'Jhooth Ki Goonj' website is exposing each and every

claim of Rahul Gandhi one by one. The name is spot-on too: Jhooth Ki Goonj," Shukla claimed. Another BJP spokesperson Pratyush Kanth said the website is examining Gandhi's claims using documented facts and sources.

"Rahul Gandhi may continue to spread his narrative, but now every claim will be met with facts and evidence. 'Jhooth Ki Goonj' is systematically examining Rahul Gandhi's claims and exposing them, one by one, with documented facts and sources," Kanth said.

Senior Supreme Court lawyer Mahesh Jethmalani also joined the BJP leaders in criticising Gandhi saying

his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' has met its "nemesis" in 'Jhooth Ki Goonj'.

"Rahul Gandhi's 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' finally has met its nemesis... From a GenZ," he said. Jethmalani claimed that the website examined 40 claims made by Gandhi during four rallies using 134 sources, with 29 rated "false" and 11 "misleading".

The website claims to fact-check statements made by Gandhi during his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' events. It examines claims on issues including employment, NEET-related expenditure and crimes against women, and provides sources and evidence alongside them.

In a first, CM Vijay sits with ministers in TN Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday made heads turn in the state Assembly when he casually moved from his chair in the House and sat besides ministers in the front row, marking a major departure from a long-standing tradition vis-a-vis seating.

Normally, the chief minister occupies a separate and spacious chair close to the Speaker's Chair and the ministers are seated separately, next to him/her, as per their seniority, in the front row.

The facing row is occupied by the Leader of the Opposition and leaders of the Legislature parties based on their numerical strength in the 234-member House with their respective party members behind.



In the afternoon session, Vijay casually moved from his chair, located on the right side of Speaker JCD Prabhakar and sat between Ministers K A Sengottaiyan (also Leader of the House) and Aadhav Arjuna.

According to a source, in the past no chief minister sat on the seat meant for ministers. Normally, the ministers or legislators change their positions for a brief

while to speak with their colleagues. But this perhaps is the first time a chief minister has shifted from his official chair to have a word with his colleagues.

Earlier in the day, Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin pointed out that the department secretaries should be asked to be present in the House when important issues are raised in the House by the members.

"The Speaker mentioned that then chief minister spoke about the Karur (stampede) incident during the previous DMK regime. Then our leader and CM (MK Stalin) was present in the House and so were the chief secretary and department secretaries. Now, both the chief minister and department secretaries are not present in the House," Udhayanidhi said.

Responding, Aadhav Arjuna said the secretaries were present in the adjoining "war room" and taking notes from the members' speeches.

The Speaker concurred with Udhayanidhi and said the senior officials will be asked to be present in the House during Assembly sessions. The CM had attended certain Government events earlier in the day, and had turned up for the session later.

Won't join Omar Govt until Statehood restored: J&K Congress chief Karra

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Pradesh Congress Committee (JKPCC) President Tariq Hameed Karra on Thursday once again rejected the ruling National Conference's invitation to join the Omar Abdullah-led Government, saying the Congress will not accept any ministerial berth until full statehood is restored to the Union Territory.

He also said the party would continue its political struggle to restore statehood and would not compromise its stand on positions in the Government.

Addressing a party gathering in Reasi, Karra said the Congress had maintained a consistent position that it would not accept ministerial berths while Jammu and Kashmir continues to remain a Union Territory.

The ruling National



Conference (NC) had approached the Congress on Wednesday with an offer to join the Council of Ministers ahead of a proposed expansion and reshuffle of the Omar Abdullah-led Government.

Karra had confirmed that the matter was under consideration, but the party has now reiterated that statehood is a precondition for entering the Cabinet.

The Congress, however, continues to support the

NC-led Government from outside. Karra has previously clarified that remaining outside the Cabinet does not mean withdrawing support to the elected Government and that the party would stand with it whenever it faces political challenges.

The Congress has supported the NC-led Government since October 2024 without taking office. In July, the Congress party had also participated in the National

Conference-led protest near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi in support of restoration of statehood to Jammu and Kashmir.

The rift between the parties deepened at the time of the Government formation in October 2024. The NC offered one ministerial berth; the Congress sought two.

The Congress decided in 2024 not to join the Government; it said it would wait for J&K's statehood to be restored.

The trust deficit triggered a fresh war of words in October last year after the Congress accused its alliance partner of betrayal in Rajya Sabha seat-sharing. Ahead of the Rajya Sabha polls for the UT's four seats, the NC announced three candidates and offered the Congress the fourth, deemed unwinnable. The Congress said it had been assured a "safe seat", and decided not to contest.

Gujarat has not seen drought since Modi became CM in 2001: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhi Nagar

Union minister Amit Shah on Thursday stated that Gujarat's water management has improved significantly since Narendra Modi took office as chief minister in 2001. He further claimed that the state has not experienced drought conditions in the last 25 years.

Shah made these comments after inaugurating a 21-acre lake constructed by a trust headed by diamond businessman and Padma Shri recipient Savjibhai Dholakia in Dudhala village, Amreli district. Shah referred to the severe droughts of 1985, 1986, and 1987, and alleged that the Congress Government at the time was involved in corruption, including at the Rafaleshwar cattle camp. He stated that measures to conserve rainwater and improve groundwater recharge were necessary to prevent future droughts.

"We were young then. People worked on drought relief, digging pits and filling them to earn daily wages. We distributed 250 grams of sukhdia (a sweet) and old sandals collected from homes to those suffering

from the drought," Shah said. He cited a public water tap near a bus stand in Rajkot that had to be lowered into a pit because the water pressure was too low to reach the surface.

"Such was the situation before Narendrabhai became chief minister in 2001," Shah said. He claimed that Modi's policies changed Saurashtra and north Gujarat from drought-prone areas to regions with better water supply.

According to Shah, the Modi Government constructed 150,000 check dams in 2003. Subsequent water conservation efforts included the Narmada canal network, SAUNI Yojana, and Sujalam. Shah stated that while the foundation stone for the Narmada project was laid by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru in 1964, the project gates were opened only after Narendra Modi became prime minister.

Shah said that the Modi Government prioritised water management by establishing the Ministry of Jal Shakti after Modi assumed office as prime minister.

The Union minister also mentioned desilting of reservoirs, adoption of drip and



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration of 'Gujarat Gaurav Sarovar', on World Lake Day in Amreli, Gujarat

sprinkler irrigation, and the 'Catch the Rain' campaign as initiatives to enhance water conservation.

"After becoming Prime Minister, Narendra Modi established the Ministry of Jal Shakti. Everyone believed in the mantra of 'Water is life,' but previous Governments never established such a Ministry," said Shah.

Shah stated that Narmada water now reaches Saurashtra, Kutch, and Khavda, with surplus water being directed to reservoirs and rivers through the SAUNI Yojana.

According to Shah, approximately 10,000 lakes in north and central Gujarat have been filled with Narmada water. He added that water conservation efforts have

involved the Government, individuals, and local communities.

Shah noted that before 2001, Gujarat faced a significant geographical imbalance in water resources, with most water concentrated in Bharuch, even though the majority of the population resided elsewhere.

"Through human effort, public awareness and a mass movement, efforts were made to correct this imbalance," Shah said, adding that check dams, lakes and other water conservation structures had helped raise groundwater levels and boost agriculture.

Shah said that Dholakia has constructed 208 lakes, which have contributed to

groundwater recharge in the region.

Shah stated that, according to Dholakia, the 21-acre lake, measuring approximately 360 metres by 260 metres and four metres deep, has stored significant water and helped revive wells in the area.

Shah commended Dholakia for his work in water conservation. He stated that national civilian honours, including the Padma Shri, Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan, and Bharat Ratna, are not intended for families or acquaintances.

"Despite building 208 lakes, Savjibhai said, 'I didn't even submit an application, and they awarded me the Padma Shri.' Savjibhai, after doing so much work for water conservation by building 208 lakes, if you had to apply for it, our Government would be considered blind," said Shah.

"Since Modi became the Chief Minister, Gujarat has not witnessed a single drought up to the year 2026. This time, everyone said a drought was imminent because of El Niño. Though there was less rainfall in some villages, the dire need to take cattle and migrate towards South Gujarat never arose.

Nations need resilient supply chains and rapid innovation to fight protracted conflicts: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jabalpur

Nations with resilient supply chains, strong industrial capacity and ability to innovate rapidly would be better equipped to withstand prolonged conflicts, said Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday in the backdrop of the more than four-year-old Russia-Ukraine war.

Against this backdrop, he said the Centre was committed to ensuring that India's armed forces were not dependent on foreign supply chains for critical defence requirements.

"Our aim is to manufacture defence equipment domestically, undertake repair and maintenance within the country, upgrade existing systems with modern technologies, and develop next-generation capabilities indigenously," Singh maintained.

He said these efforts reflected India's emergence as a global manufacturing hub, a reliable technology partner and a trusted defence partner.

Singh made the remarks



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh performs a ritual as Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav looks on during the 'Bhoomi Pujan' ceremony for the T-72 and T-90 Tank Overhaul Project at the Vehicle Factory in Jabalpur on Thursday

after laying the foundation stone of a ₹472-crore facility for the overhaul of T-series battle tanks at the 57-year-old Vehicle Factory Jabalpur (VF).

Highlighting the changing nature of warfare, he noted countries possessing advanced technologies, resilient supply chains, robust industrial capabilities and dynamic innovation ecosystems would be in a stronger position to sustain themselves during long-drawn conflicts.

Singh said the T-series tank overhaul facility would help build a resilient domestic supply chain by generating demand for a wide

range of mechanical, electrical, electronic and hydraulic components, assemblies and subsystems.

"The sourcing of these items would create opportunities for local MSMEs in manufacturing and ancillary services associated with tank overhauling, while helping develop a strong and self-sustaining industrial ecosystem," he stated.

The project would prove to be a boon for soldiers and generate employment opportunities in Jabalpur and surrounding areas, including for workers, youth, small entrepreneurs and other sections of the local population, Singh said.

CEC Gyanesh Kumar interacts with BLOs, hails them for ground efforts



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Describing BLOs as the foundation and backbone of Indian democracy, Chief Election Commissioner of India (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Thursday interacted with field-level poll machinery and youth delegates during the EC's Regional Conference on "ELC & ECINET" held at Kalaivanar Arangam here.

The day-long conference, organised by the ECI in coordination with the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer, Tamil Nadu, focused on grassroots electoral preparedness and voter awareness across Tamil Nadu and Puducherry.

Interacting with over 500 Booth Level Officers (BLO) from 14 surrounding districts, the CEC commended their dedicated door-to-door verification and on-ground efforts.

"Booth-level officers are the foundation of any democracy. The booth-level officers of Tamil Nadu, as well as all parts of the country, are working booth to booth, house to house to ensure that the electoral rolls and voter lists are correct, cleaned up, and free of mistakes. The Election Commission of India salutes them," the CEC said,

adding that valuable suggestions shared by the officers would be reviewed by the Commission for appropriate action. The session with field functionaries concluded with a vote of thanks by the District Election Officer (DEO), Chennai.

Addressing an afternoon gathering of nearly 1,000 delegates, including first-time voters, students, and educators representing 300 schools, 75 colleges, and 25 universities across 38 districts of Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, the CEC urged young citizens to champion democratic values, adopt informed voting practices, and actively drive voter literacy through institutional Electoral Literacy Clubs (ELCs).

Delegates also participated in interactive exhibitions and witnessed live demonstrations covering essential stages of the electoral cycle, including electoral roll preparation, voting procedures, and vote counting.

Earlier, speaking to reporters at the Chennai airport, Kumar congratulated both Tamil Nadu and Puducherry for achieving the highest number of votes polled as well as the highest voting percentages in the recently held Assembly elections.

Need robust Indo-German arbitration mechanism as trade grows: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Highlighting substantial and growing economic relationship between India and Germany, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Thursday said there is a necessity of having trust in international commerce and a robust arbitration mechanism can build the confident ecosystem.

Speaking at the Indo-German arbitration conclave in Berlin, Germany, CJI Kant pointed out that disputes are a natural feature of commercial activity but their existence does not necessarily indicate a failure of trust.

"What matters is whether the legal system provides a reliable mechanism through



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

which disagreements can be resolved without undermining the commercial relationship itself," he said, adding that an arbitration agreement is more than a procedural clause in a contract which represents a commitment to a method of resolving future disagree-

ments. "India and Germany share a substantial and growing economic relationship. German investment in India spans important sectors, while Indian companies are increasingly entering the German market. As these relationships become more sophisticated, the con-

tracts that support them also become more complex," he said.

He further said that long-term supply arrangements, infrastructure projects, technology agreements, joint ventures and cross-border investments inevitably raise questions that may not always be resolved through negotiation alone.

CJI Kant pointed out that the arbitral process must be supported by efficient institutions, capable arbitrators and courts that intervene only where it is extremely necessary, without delaying or displacing the arbitral process.

"International commerce depends upon trust at every stage. Businesses must trust

their contractual partners and have confidence in the legal framework. When a dispute arises, they must be confident that there exists an institution capable of resolving it fairly, efficiently and in accordance with law. Arbitration can fulfil this role only when the entire ecosystem surrounding it commands that confidence," CJI Kant said.

He emphasised the need for specialised arbitral institutions, arbitrators, counsel and, equally importantly, the courts that support the arbitral process.

The CJI said institutional trust is not created overnight and is built through consistent practice, professional integrity and sustained engagement.

Two-wheelers to have low-beam auto headlamps from April 2028

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From next April, automatic headlamps in new two-wheelers will work only in passing beam (low beam) mode, and headlamps of cars and other vehicles will have less intense illumination to reduce glare considering that such lights cause visual discomfort or impairs the vision of other road users. The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) has proposed amendments to the Central Motor Vehicles rules to make it mandatory for automatic headlamps in new two-wheelers to work only in passing beam (low beam mode).

The move is aimed at reducing glare and improving vision of other road users. The MoRTH, in a draft notification said, "In the principal rules...provided further that, on and after 1st April 2028, the automatic head lamp on operation shall operate in passing beam only," it said.



The amendments in automotive vehicle standards are being made because efforts to persuade drivers and make them aware of the need to use low-beam mode have not yielded desired results.

At present, the Automatic Headlamp On (AHO) system can switch on both low beam and high beam modes depending on vehicle settings. The proposed rule man-

dates that when the automatic system is active, the headlamp will be on low beam.

According to the draft notification, as for high-intensity headlamps, the maximum permissible intensity has been reduced from 1.5 lakh candela or cd (official base unit of luminous intensity) to 1 lakh cd for two-wheelers.

The maximum permissible inten-

sity for four-wheelers (cars) has been reduced from 2.25 lakh cd to 1.5 lakh cd.

It has also been proposed that the mounting height of main-beam headlamps be equivalent to that prescribed for passing-beam headlamps. These measures target one of the major causes of night-time road crashes in India — drivers using headlamps on high beam in urban areas, which can temporarily blind motorists approaching from the opposite direction, reducing visibility and increasing the risk of crashes.

In another safety measure, buses and other heavy vehicles could be required to use genuine reflective tapes. The aim is to make such vehicles more visible to motorists during nighttime driving and periods of poor weather.

If implemented, the proposals would mark a significant tightening of vehicle lighting standards with road safety and glare reduction as key objectives.

Raksha Bandhan symbolises feelings respect and mutual care, says President



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday greeted citizens on the eve of Raksha Bandhan, saying the festival symbolises feelings of respect and mutual responsibility not only between brothers and sisters but also among families, friends and society.

"This festival reminds us that every relationship rests on the pillars of trust, sensitivity and mutual cooperation," President Murmu said in a message. The festival of Raksha Bandhan has been an integral part of our culture and tradition since ancient times, she said. "In many 'shlokas' and 'mantras', we find the words 'Raksha, Ma Chala, Ma Chala'. These words express the imploration, 'May this bond of protection continue forever'," she said.

Raksha Bandhan has become popular as a social festival in which sisters tie a Rakhi on the wrists of their brothers, the president said.

"This symbolises the feelings of warmth, respect and mutual responsibility, not only between brothers and sisters but also among siblings, families, friends and society," she said.



Editor's
TAKE

Himalayan catastrophe

The warming of Himalayas is turning them into a ticking time bomb; only concerted action by Nepal, India and China can avert disaster

On the morning of August 26, a slab of glacier broke off a mountainside on the Nepal-Tibet border, crashed into a valley and blocked the Lhende River. The lake it formed burst almost instantly, sending ice, rock and water down the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli rivers into Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts, and across into Tibet's Gyirong County. Nepal's police have confirmed over 160 dead and hundreds missing, among them more than a hundred Indians, many on the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage, and foreign nationals from half a dozen other countries. Bridges, highways and roughly an eighth of Nepal's hydropower capacity were knocked out within minutes.

The immediate trigger was natural, violent enough that seismographs first mistook it for an earthquake. But natural is not the same as normal. Nepal's glaciers are retreating up to 15 metres a year, and glacial-origin floods across the Hindu Kush Himalaya, once expected roughly once a decade, numbered three in just two months last year, according to ICIMOD, the region's mountain-research body. What has shifted is temperature, not geology.

Layered on top is a man-made factor: hydropower stations, roads and settlements pushed into unstable valleys with almost no early-warning cover, in a country that emits less than a tenth of one per cent of the world's carbon. Cutting the toll of the next flood, and there will be one, means treating glacial lakes as the infrastructure risk they are: systematic mapping of the region's most dangerous lakes, sensor-based warning systems extended from a handful of pilot valleys to every settlement below a glacier, zoning that keeps construction off riverbanks, and hydropower design built for catastrophic failure, not average monsoon rainfall.

Nepal and its neighbours have already piloted much of this; what's missing is scale and money. This flood crossed from Tibet into Nepal in minutes, and from Nepal into India within hours, since the Trishuli becomes the Gandak, putting Bihar on flood alert before rescue teams had finished searching Rasuwa.

A hazard indifferent to borders needs cooperation that matches it: real-time hydrological data-sharing between Nepal, China and India, built on existing frameworks such as ICIMOD's glacial-lake inventories and the Koshi Basin Initiative, not one-off goodwill after each disaster. The UN's response has followed the standard emergency script: Secretary-General António Guterres's condolences, followed swiftly by the WFP, WHO, UNICEF, UNDP and OCHA deploying rations, medical kits and satellite mapping.

Nepal needed monitoring and money years before this week, not sympathy after it. India moved with familiar speed: Modi's call to his Nepali counterpart Balendra Shah, the promise of all possible humanitarian assistance with NDRF teams on standby. India has as much at stake in Himalayan glacier monitoring as Nepal does. First response should now make room for first investment: shared early-warning networks, not relief flights after the water has fallen.

SCO Summit: India's Eurasian balancing act

As the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation turns 25, its Bishkek summit comes at a time of deepening geopolitical turbulence. For India, the grouping is more than a regional forum: it is a crucial platform to advance strategic autonomy, counter terrorism, strengthen ties with Central Asia and secure connectivity across Eurasia while navigating the growing influence of China



PARUL
CHANDRA

The upcoming annual leaders' summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) at Bishkek in Kyrgyzstan, which PM Narendra Modi will attend, comes amid ongoing geopolitical shifts and strategic realignments that continue to trigger severe global economic consequences.

The motto of the summit on August 31-September 1 - '25 years of the SCO: Together Towards Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity' - serves both as an ambitious goal and a test of regional cooperation.

The summit takes place against a backdrop of global turmoil driven by Russia's long-drawn war with Ukraine and the unabating US-Israel-Iran conflict. Both Russia and Iran are SCO members. These conflicts have had a major impact on the global economy and the SCO motto, therefore, assumes even greater significance.

Over its 25-year history, the SCO has expanded considerably. It now includes 10 member states, two observer states and 15 dialogue partners that encompass a vast geographical area, diverse cultures and people. For India, SCO membership provides a crucial platform to pursue its strategic interests in the vast Eurasia region.

India transitioned from an observer state in 2005 to full membership in 2017 alongside Pakistan, whose inclusion was backed by its all-weather ally, China. The other full members include the Central Asian countries of Kazakhstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan. Its two newest members are Iran, which joined the grouping in 2023, and Belarus in 2024. Afghanistan and Mongolia serve as observer states.

Additionally, the SCO's 15 dialogue partners reflect the growing interest in the grouping. They are Egypt, Qatar, Kuwait, UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Maldives, Myanmar, Cambodia, Lao PDR, Azerbaijan and Armenia.

With the 10 member states encompassing a huge geographical spread of around 36 million sq km and over 3.4 billion people, India recognises the geopolitical value of remaining deeply engaged in the SCO at both multilateral and bilateral levels. PM Modi, for instance, will be meeting Russian President Vladimir Putin, among others, on the margins of the summit.

India's SCO membership also underlines its strategic autonomy in participating in a non-Western-aligned forum alongside major powers like Russia and China. Membership ensures India



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AND THE
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NEXUS

The writer is a policy analyst who writes on foreign and strategic issues

a seat at the table, while keeping a close eye on China's regional ambitions and the China-Pakistan nexus.

As an economic powerhouse, China often seeks to dominate the SCO, which has its secretariat in Beijing. India consistently uses the platform to counter these dynamics.

At the SCO summit at Tianjin in China last year, India reiterated its opposition to Beijing's ambitious Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), with PM Modi emphasising that connectivity efforts "must uphold the principles of sovereignty and territorial integrity".

In a strong message to China, which has often used "salami slicing" tactics to encroach on territory India claims as its own, PM Modi also noted: "Connectivity that bypasses sovereignty ultimately loses both trust and meaning." India remains the sole SCO member state that does not endorse the BRI.

For India, SCO membership is both a strategic and economic imperative. PM Modi spelt out the three pillars upon which India's policy towards the SCO is predicated at the Tianjin summit last year: Security, Connectivity and Opportunity.

India's membership of the SCO is also critical for its connectivity strategy across Eurasia. With Pakistan blocking India's direct overland access to Afghanistan and beyond to Central Asia, New Delhi must explore alternative transit routes to these regions.

Building robust ties with the 'stans' of Central Asia, which India views as part of its extended neighbourhood, is crucial to balance China's heavy influence in the region. The SCO serves as a useful platform to find common ground with them on various issues, including connectivity, energy, security, trade, critical minerals and counter-terrorism.

It's noteworthy that en route to Bishkek, PM Modi will also be travelling to Uzbekistan, with

which it has robust defence cooperation, to build on its strategic partnership.

The 'stans' are particularly important for New Delhi's efforts at connectivity with Central Asia and even beyond to Europe. There is convergence of interests in this regard, with these landlocked nations exploring alternative routes for connectivity.

India has been banking on the INSTC (International North South Transport Corridor) as a vital connectivity link to Central Asia. The ambitious project, however, is a long way away from fruition.

India's plans to access these nations and Afghanistan via the Iranian port of Chabahar, too, have been in the doldrums owing to US sanctions and the current heightened tensions in West Asia. On the security front, the SCO provides India with a vital platform to draw attention to terror, especially emanating from Pakistan. Last year, for instance, India highlighted the terror strikes carried out at Pahalgalam in Kashmir by Pak-backed attackers. India acknowledges that the SCO-RATS (Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure), headquartered at Tashkent in Uzbekistan, has played a significant role in the fight against terrorism.

At the Bishkek summit, India will undoubtedly press ahead with its focus on counter-terrorism and regional connectivity. Additionally, as member states discuss establishing an SCO Development Bank to fund infrastructure, India will likely seek more clarity on its structure to ensure it aligns with territorial sovereignty principles. Ultimately, India's participation in the Bishkek summit is not merely a diplomatic routine. It's driven by a pragmatic focus on strategic autonomy, counter-terrorism, and Eurasian access. India should do its utmost to leverage the SCO to safeguard its own strategic interests and monitor regional dynamics.

PIC TALK



Revelers throw tomatoes at each other during the annual "Tomatina" tomato fight fiesta, in the village of Bunol near Valencia, Spain

PHOTO: PTI



RAJYOGI BRAHMA
KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Over the last several decades, the topic of spirituality has come to the forefront of public and professional consciousness. With the dawn of a new century, spirituality has received increased coverage in the media and more discussion in the workplace, in politics and in education. To many, spirituality represents a necessary essence of life that energises both thoughts and actions.

To others, spirituality is a belief in a power operating in the universe greater than oneself. Still others define it as a sense of interconnectedness with all living creatures, and an awareness of the purpose and meaning of life. However, the lack of a universally accepted theory or definition of spirituality has created a lot of confusion as well as misunderstanding

in society. Many people confuse spirituality with religion and so bring pre-existing beliefs about the impact of religion to discussions about spirituality.

Though all religions emphasise spirituality as being an important part of faith, what really needs to be answered is whether it is possible to be 'spiritual' without necessarily being a part of an organised religious community?

Recognising the difference between spirituality and religion can be a great way to begin to understand what spirituality actually means.

Those people who profess their faith in Almighty and higher beings, in living life virtuously or in following the rituals pertaining to their faith are known as religious-minded. However, there is a difference between being religious and being spiritual. Even though books and information on spirituality have flooded the world, there is still a lot of vagueness and contradiction about knowledge of the soul, its original nature, abode and role in world drama.

The first step towards being spiritual is to be soul-conscious and be free from all limitations and bondages of the physical world.

A spiritual being is aware of his/her real identity - of being a soul and a child of the Supreme Soul - and is also aware of one's true nature of being peaceful, pure, blissful and loveful. When we play our worldly roles with this awareness, we live a truly spiritual life.

We also begin to see everyone as souls and, instead of creating karmic bondages in relationships, we begin to empower each other and remain detached and loving.

Self-realization is the goal of many spiritual schools of thought, but most people go beyond satiating their curiosity to learn something new, and once they learn it or experience it, their excitement fades and they start searching for other sources of intellectual stimulation.

A spiritual person always remains content with the self and devotes his time not to material pursuits but tends to remain in the company of the divine, thereby experiencing true love, peace and happiness which are more lasting than material attainments. Such a person will see everyone as souls; be loveful to every person in this world regardless of one's religion, country, gender and other physical traits.

When we would understand the above definition of a real spiritual being, we would be spiritually awakened and enlightened and get directly connected to the Supreme Being, who would lead us to the path of self-transformation, which would further lead to world transformation. So, let's embark on this journey of becoming a 'Spiritual Being' through self-realisation and introspection.

The writer is a popular columnist and a spiritual teacher

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FROM DEGREES TO LIVELIHOODS: EDUCATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

The NITI Aayog's August 2026 report, *Reimagining Skilling for Viksit Bharat@2047*, notes that early exposure to vocational options remains limited.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 envisages vocational exposure for 50 per cent of students by 2025 and all students by 2030, but implementation remains at an early stage. It also points out that the lack of such exposure limits informed career choices and the development of foundational employability skills. Therefore, corrective action must begin much earlier. Vocational and practical skills should be strengthened in schools, enabling students to discover their aptitude, interests and potential career paths. At the time of college entry, professional career counselling, based on aptitude, emerging employment opportunities and

local economic needs, should help students make informed choices rather than simply pursuing generic degrees. Colleges should not be sustained merely to protect existing staffing patterns or fill seats by introducing additional courses; institutions with genuine potential should receive greater support. At the same time, higher public investment in infrastructure, manufacturing, healthcare services and other labour-intensive sectors is needed to create employment opportunities, strengthen livelihoods and encourage private investment.

Education must ultimately connect learning with meaningful work. A stronger focus on practical skills, career guidance and employment generation can help young people move from degrees to sustainable livelihoods.

BRIJ BHUSHAN GOYAL | LUDHIANA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

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THARCIOUS S FERNANDO | CHENNAI

VINEETH KUMAR | KERALA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Raksha Bandhan: A bond beyond blood

Raksha Bandhan, or "the knot of protection", is here. Though the origin of Rakhi can be traced to the Mahabharata, with religious and historical references as well, the tradition of sisters tying rakhis around their brothers' wrists has transcended cultures and religions.

Rakhi is not just a thread; it is a promise tied with love and secured for life. It hinges on mutual respect, care and affection. It is a celebration of trust, companionship and the enduring bond between two people.

When women tie rakhis on the wrists of men who are not their biological brothers, they foster the magnificent Indian concept of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam", the much-celebrated Sanskrit phrase meaning "the world is one family". This "world is one family" is a much-needed emotion in troubled times. No race, religion or nationality should come in the way of people-to-people interaction and bonding. A brother-sister relationship comes from the heart, not from blood.

The bond between the two is sometimes tightly woven, at times loosely held, but never broken. They are siblings by chance, but friends by choice.

Parandur airport: Back to square one?

The decision of the Tamil Nadu Government, led by C. Joseph Vijay, to cancel the proposed greenfield airport at Parandur is disappointing and could have serious implications for the State's industrial growth.

The project had reportedly completed much of the necessary due diligence, with financial closure at an advanced stage. Major industries, including multinational companies located in and around Parandur, had welcomed the airport as a long-standing requirement.

The decision could send a wrong signal to potential investors and create apprehension that a change of government could also mean a change in policies. Such uncertainty may affect Tamil Nadu's ability to attract and retain investment.

The government has cited the interests of farmers as the principal reason for shelving the project. However, the reported statement that the 1,800 acres already acquired would instead be used for other industrial purposes raises questions about how farmers' interests are being protected. Tamil Nadu needs consistent and predictable policies. Major development projects should be assessed objectively on their long-term economic, social and environmental implications rather than being reversed to fulfil political commitments

Tackling motor insurance fraud

The Supreme Court's directive ordering states to establish dedicated Special Investigation Teams (SITs) highlights a deeply entrenched vulnerability within India's motor insurance framework. The investigation into a compensation scam of "enormous proportion" involving falsified vehicle accident records exposes a crisis that extends far beyond simple criminal deceit. It represents a systemic failure that inflicts severe, long-term economic damage on the nation's insurance ecosystem.

Fabricated claims and staged accidents artificially inflate payout liabilities for insurance companies. This rampant bleed drains underwriting reserves, distorts actuarial risk pricing and worsens loss ratios across the industry. Consequently, insurance providers are forced to adjust for these financial leaks by hiking premium rates. Honest, law-abiding policyholders are ultimately left to absorb the financial burden of a fraudulent minority through inflated annual costs. Furthermore, such widespread malpractices erode public trust in judicial compensation channels designed to aid genuine victims.

State-level SITs must combine prosecution with technology. Linking traffic, police and vehicle records can make claims verification tamper-proof, protecting insurers and consumers.

Himalayan tragedy: A disaster in Nepal, a warning for India

The disaster in Nepal is a stark reminder that natural hazards do not respect political borders. What begins as a catastrophe in a remote mountain valley can threaten lives and infrastructure in India. India and Nepal need to move from flood warnings to real-time, basin-wide impact forecasting and coordinated risk management



SATYENDRA SINGH

A catastrophic flash flood hit Nepal's Himalayan border area on August 26, killing people and causing massive destruction. Houses have been inundated; roads and bridges have been destroyed or washed away, and infrastructure like electricity have been affected. Rescue efforts are ongoing in inaccessible locations; meanwhile, it is still unclear how much damage the mega disaster has caused. However, this is not just Nepal's problem, but India's, especially Bihar and eastern Uttar Pradesh's. The reason is obvious: rivers carrying Himalayan waters do not recognise political boundaries.

So far, the exact reason for the flash flood is being investigated. According to initial findings, an ice-rock or glacial avalanche could have occurred, possibly along with a temporary river blockade and sudden releasing of huge amount of water, rock, and sediments. An earthquake is also one of the reasons. The idea of glacial lake outburst has so far not got enough evidence.

What should be remembered in general is that flash flood in the Himalayas is the ultimate result of a chain of events starting with glacier or slope instability, followed by river blockade and huge release of water, rocks, and sediments. The Himalayas are gradually turning into the sources of cascading disasters.

The present flooding started from the upper parts of Bhotekoshi/Lhende river system at the border between Tibet and Nepal. The flood wave travelled from the Bhot Koshi and Trishuli river systems to the Narayani and further down the river as the Gandak in India. This explains why there has been fear for the downstream areas of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

When the Rivers of Nepal Flow into India

To appreciate India's vulnerability, one needs to move away from the political map and consider the river-basin map. While politically Nepal and India are two separate countries, hydrologically they are one system. Himalayan water feeds the irrigation, domestic and ecological needs as well as livelihoods of millions, but if anything goes wrong in the upper basins, these very rivers can be transformed into destructive rivers.

Sarda, Ghaghra, Rapti, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, Kamla and Kosi are some of the rivers contributing to floods in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar that originate in or travel through Nepal. India and Nepal already have bilateral agreements concerning flood forecasting and water management. The present disaster is a good opportunity for strengthening them.

Gandak is particularly relevant to the present situation. Narayani River becomes Gandak when it enters India and travels through Uttar Pradesh and Bihar and finally meets the Ganges River. Bihar is also vulnerable to other Himalayan rivers such as Kosi, Bagmati, Burhi Gandak and Ghaghra.

An unexpected outburst after an avalanche, landslide, or flooding of a river due to the formation of a dam would give very little warning time. Hence, the early warning system should not only alert about the crossing of river levels by a river. It should also warn about which villages can be flooded, what infrastructure would be affected and where the search and rescue teams and aid materials must be deployed. India requires transitioning from hazard prediction to impact prediction.

The hazard environment in the Himalayas is changing. Changes in temperature and climatic conditions have influenced rainfall patterns and the behaviour of glaciers and slopes, while roadways, tunnels, hydropower plants, tourist destinations, and development in general are increasing in fragile regions. Satellite imagery, remote sensing, automatic devices, drones and artificial intelligence technology can help a lot in monitoring. But technology alone is not enough for preparedness. A warning displayed on a government dashboard is not very useful if it does not reach those affected by it. Villagers, farmers, schoolteachers and families have to know what it means and what needs to be done to protect themselves. Equally important is the local knowledge about which embankments will collapse first, which roads will become impassable and how floodwaters will inundate their villages. Thus, the goal should



be to define the affected population, identify critical infrastructure, evacuate routes and places, as well as position trained local teams and relief forces beforehand.

Lessons from Uttarakhand

The recent catastrophe in Nepal makes us recall a lesson that India had been taught earlier. The disaster in Uttarakhand clearly showed the interaction of heavy rains, floods, landslides, geological instability, settlements, infrastructure and development. The basic lesson learned was obvious: natural hazard turns into disaster due to the vulnerability of society.

The lessons teach us about zoning, restrictions on building in risky zones, Disaster Impact Assessment along with Environmental Impact Assessment, slope stabilization, protection of ecosystems, better warning systems and community preparedness. But still: do we learn from disasters or merely document them?

The solution does not lie in halting development. Connectivity, growth and security depend on roads, tunnels, hydropower and tourism infrastructure. The question is where and how such development happens.

Development in the mountains cannot happen in the same way as development on more stable terrains. Geomorphological and environmental assessment is crucial for any hydropower or tunnel project. Consequently, Disaster Impact Assessment must become a necessary element of infrastructure development in fragile Himalayan regions.

Nature needs to play a role in disaster-risk reduction as well. Forests, wetlands, stable slopes and healthy water catchments protect from erosion, runoff and siltation. Thus, their conservation and restoration should become complementary to engineering solutions.

Transboundary Himalayan Resilience Agenda

The Nepal tragedy proves one thing for certain: disaster resilience in the Himalayas must be transboundary in nature. India and Nepal must work together to create a Himalayan transboundary disaster risk management framework taking into account their shared hydrological basins. Satellite imagery, glacier and glacial lake assessment, avalanches and landslides monitoring, earthquake data, precipitation forecasts and river level monitoring should all be integrated into early warning and impact forecasting system.

The response has to be proactive, not reactive. There should be no need for downstream governments to react only after the disaster crosses the international border, but the warning must come before the flood does.

We have to shift our approach from relief to risk reduction, from hazard assessment to impact prediction, from project-level initiatives to regional water basin planning, and from national activities to transboundary cooperation.

Bihar and Uttar Pradesh should take note of this particular alarm. The lives of people downstream will rely heavily on choices being made thousands of kilometres away, perhaps even outside of India. The Himalayas are not only a natural dividing line between countries; they are a single, interconnected ecosystem.

While we cannot control our geography, we can definitely change the way we respond to whatever our geography may present to us. The real choice is not development versus disaster-risk reduction. It is risk-blind development versus risk-informed development. This was the message that Uttarakhand delivered to us, and Nepal's misfortune serves to reaffirm it. In case the Himalaya shakes, the plains must be ready. If we want to secure people, infrastructure, agriculture, energy systems and ecosystems of the Himalaya-Ganga basin, one rule must reign supreme: The river basin, not the political boundary, should be the basic unit of disaster-risk management.

The writer is former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management, Government of India

After Red Corridor: India's post-Naxal challenge



VIKAS YADAV

For nearly six decades, Left-Wing Extremism remained one of India's most serious internal security challenges. Beginning with the Naxalbari movement in West Bengal, it developed into a prolonged armed insurgency across parts of central and eastern India.

In 2026, India reached an important turning point. On March 31, the Union government declared that the country had effectively achieved its objective of becoming free from Left-Wing Extremism. According to government data, the number of affected districts declined from 126 in 2014 to zero by March-April 2026. Naxal-related incidents also fell from 870 in 2014 to 234 in 2025, while fatalities declined from 310 to 100.

However, the decline in violence raises an equally important question: what happens after an insurgency loses its territory, weapons and organisational strength? The real challenge is to ensure that conditions enabling extremism do not return permanently.

India's approach has gradually moved beyond security operations towards a combination of security, development, governance and rehabilitation. The objective is not simply to establish security control, but to ensure that citizens experience the presence of the State through schools, hospitals, markets, public services and employment opportunities.

Bastar represents this transition clearly. For years, its difficult terrain and forests provided space for Maoist groups, while poor connectivity restricted the reach of government institutions. Yet reclaiming territory is only the first step. Roads must remain functional, schools need teachers, health centres require doctors and medicines, and young people need meaningful employment.

Rehabilitation is another major challenge of the post-Naxal phase. Security operations can weaken an armed organisation, but the long-term outcome depends on what happens to those who surrender. Education, vocational training, identity documents, housing, employment, psychological support and acceptance within society are necessary for genuine reintegration.

The experiences of surrendered cadres in Chhattisgarh illustrate this possibility. Some former insurgents have entered ordinary professions such as tailoring, plumbing and other service-sector work. Every former combatant successfully integrated into civilian life reduces the possibility of renewed recruitment and demonstrates that a peaceful alternative is available.

Another important issue is the possible participation of former Maoists in democratic politics. A democracy can accommodate radical or unpopular political opinions as long as political activity remains within the constitutional and legal framework. A clear distinction must therefore be maintained between political belief and political violence. The State must act firmly against violence, unlawful activities and links with armed organisations. This distinction is particularly important in the debate over who should be described as a "Naxal." Treating different forms of political activity as identical can weaken democratic debate. The most effective approach is one based on evidence, law and due process.

The post-Naxal challenge also extends into the information space. The weakening of armed groups does not automatically remove the narratives and grievances that contributed to their influence. Social media can spread political messages far beyond the regions where the insurgency once operated. Therefore, credible public communication is essential. The State must explain its policies, address legitimate grievances and demonstrate visible development outcomes, while security agencies identify genuine extremist activity without treating ordinary disagreement as a security threat.

Financial networks also require continued attention. Strong action against unlawful financing should strengthen, rather than weaken, public confidence in institutions.

Security agencies cannot simply withdraw after the declaration of a Naxal-free India. The more sustainable approach is a gradual transition from intensive counter-insurgency operations to normal policing and civilian administration.

Economic development will also be central to lasting peace. Businesses, cooperatives, self-help groups and skill-development programmes can create employment and alternatives to underground networks, particularly for young people and former insurgents. Communities with functioning markets, secure livelihoods, education and opportunities for advancement are less vulnerable to the appeal of armed politics. Ultimately, the success of an insurgency can be measured through statistics such as fewer attacks, deaths and affected districts. It is visible when children attend school regularly, patients can reach hospitals, farmers can access markets, young people find employment and former insurgents rebuild their lives.

India has made substantial progress in dismantling the armed infrastructure of Left-Wing Extremism. Yet the next phase will determine whether this achievement becomes permanent. The task now is to ensure that the vacuum left by insurgency is filled with roads, schools, jobs, accountable governance, democratic participation, justice and sustained public trust.

India may have moved beyond the era of the Red Corridor. The guns may be falling silent, but the real challenge is to ensure that peace, development and democratic participation take their place permanently across formerly affected regions and communities in the future.



The writer is an Assistant Professor of Political Science at the University of Delhi

Gen Alpha's AI shadow: Protecting the right to outgrow childhood data



ANURADHA PS

For previous generations, childhood slowly faded from their memory. For Gen Alpha, it may become something that machines remember. Search engines, recommendation systems, digital classrooms and AI tutors as part of everyday learning do more than just capture the things children do: they infer what they do, predict what they like and create opportunities for them. This is the start of an 'AI shadow' — a series of guesses and presumptions that a machine draws from a child's online footprints. This is important, as AI continues to grow up quicker than the organisations that regulate it.

The child that India is today is an impressive digital kid. According to the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) 2024, 89.1 per cent of adolescent youths aged 14-16 mentioned they had a smartphone in their home. However, how they use that access demonstrates it: 76 per cent of them use their smartphones most often for social media, and only 57 per cent use them most often for educational purposes. This is also highlighted in UNICEF India's guidance, which states that access to the internet still has to catch up with the institutional infrastructure, as only 63.5 per cent of schools in India have internet facilities as part of

their infrastructure. A study conducted by UNICEF U-Report also reveals that 40 per cent of young people use the internet for more than four hours a day. The key change is not that kids are growing up digital, however. Digital interaction is becoming a regular component of childhood architecture. AI is now taking things one step further.

India's experience is part of the global shift. In June 2026, a UNICEF analysis found that at least 20 million children had used AI across 10 countries. About 13 million used AI for studies and homework, while over 2 million used it for guidance on personal matters. AI has become part of childhood, offering opportunities such as personalised tutoring, one-to-one support and help in identifying learning gaps.

UNICEF's Guidance on AI and Children 3.0 acknowledges this potential but cautions that evidence on AI's impact on children remains limited. It urges 'child-centred' AI systems that safeguard children's rights, privacy, development and autonomy. The more personalised AI becomes, the more information it requires. An AI tutor can identify what a child struggles with, what interests them and which explanations work. This can make it an effective teaching aid, but also create an 'AI shadow'. If algorithms repeatedly predict what a child can or should do, those predictions may influence future choices.

Not all of these risks are equal. The first digital divide was in part access, coupled with access to a device and connection or electricity. The second was skills - who knew how to use technology effectively. The new polarisation may be one over the interpretation, who is interpreting them with tech-



nology. In a recent report, UNICEF stated that unequal access to and skills with digital technologies can exacerbate inequalities in childhood: 'Childhood in a Digital World'. It also has some more recent AI evidence, as children were more than three times more likely than their parents to say they had used AI across the 10 countries studied. In most of these countries, at least three-quarters of parents/caregivers were never users of AI, thus creating an AI usage divide within the family. If a parent is not familiar with the AI environment, it's difficult to guide a child through it. The disparity in AI use could thus not just be between children with access to AI and children without access to AI.

International law and the data-protection regime in India already acknowledge that children should be afforded special protection. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, Section 9, mandates, for the processing of a child's personal data, that their verifiable consent be obtained, and pro-

hibits tracking, behavioural monitoring and targeted advertising directed at children, except under narrow exceptions. The Rules were further modified in 2025 to include a few exceptions for the safety and welfare of children. These are key safeguards. However, AI poses a more challenging question than traditional data protection: How to protect information that is not directly disclosed?

UNICEF's new guidance is very clear about this. It calls for the storage of children's data for as long as necessary, to ensure that data gathered regarding a child does not accompany him/her when he/she grows up. It also requires transparency, accountability, fairness and child protection with regard to children's developing autonomy. It indicates a principle which India needs to take seriously: developmental data minimisation. Gather materials required for a child's learning and/or security. Keep it as short a time as possible. Don't let childhood behavioural profiles go undocumented. Then the "algorithmic forgetfulness" principle should be in place. Children should be given the opportunity to develop beyond the machine's understanding of themselves. This is really a 'right to be wrong' thing. One of the greatest assets of AI is its ability to recognise patterns. Change is the strength of childhood. The risk is that a system designed on the basis of AI will end up categorising what the child is good at today as what he or she should be tomorrow. The impact of AI on children's cognitive development, emotional dependence and exposure to harm is still emerging, according to UNICEF. UNICEF explained this evidence was limited in scope and that the adoption of AI was quickening the pace. This is possibly one

of the key facts. There are more technologies being scaled up than there is evidence of consequences.

The agenda for change in India is progressing: India must not wait for the AI shadow to tag its children as a permanent reality of their lives to contemplate its meaning. There are four steps that are critical:

1. Literacy in school beyond just prompting and fact-checking, empowering children to comprehend the functioning of systems and their ability to produce outputs and make predictions.
2. Support materials and advice for parents to help them navigate the AI environments their children use.
3. Regular and clear requirements for businesses to render the processing of children's data understandable, appropriate and traceable.
4. Restrictions on retention and inference that childhood data is not an implicit credential for a lifetime.

Most importantly, the information that is gathered during childhood should not be a secret credential for a lifetime. AI's promise is that it will be able to better understand learners. What risks do you face is that it might start to shape them. Gen Alpha might be the first generation to rise up with an AI shadow. The biggest danger is that AI will know too much, too soon and that it will confuse a moment in childhood for a lifetime map. Prior generations thought it was a given they would be able to become a person who their youths couldn't imagine. Gen Alpha deserves the same freedom.

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 Order Order

Calcutta HC denies TMC faction access to four frozen accounts



The Calcutta High Court on Thursday refused to pass an interim order allowing the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction to operate four debit-frozen bank accounts holding around ₹804 crore, observing that granting such relief would undermine its earlier order permitting the political party to meet day-to-day expenses.

The matter will come up for hearing again after the Durga Puja vacation, before which the parties will file their affidavits stating their respective positions, the court directed. Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya observed that passing a further order permitting operation of the four accounts would render his previous order “faulted”.

The TMC had sought permission to operate four accounts with public sector banks that were debit-frozen by West Bengal Police, claiming there were lacunae in the FIRs related to the freezing.The state Government submitted that steps had been taken in the criminal prosecution in accordance with law and sought permission for the police to continue its investigation. After hearing the parties, Justice Bhattacharyya said in view of his July 9 order appointing a special officer to clear and meet the day-to-day expenses of the political entity from three other debit-frozen accounts, no further order was required at this stage regarding the four accounts. A report by the cybercrime police station of the Bidhannagar Police Commissionerate on the investigation was also placed before the court.

The Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction had moved the high court challenging the freezing of the four bank accounts by the police cyber cell on July 7.The state police had earlier debit-frozen three other private bank accounts of the TMC, which was challenged before the high court, the party’s lawyer Menaka Guruswamy said. (PTI)

Criminal defamation case against Pinaki Misra quashed



The Delhi High Court has quashed criminal defamation proceedings against senior advocate and former Member of Parliament Pinaki Misra, in a case alleging that he had said certain objectionable words about a lawyer in an interview.

The high court also quashed a trial court’s April 2019 order summoning Misra to face trial for defamation, saying permitting the proceedings to continue would not advance the cause of justice.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma said the complainant had examined himself as the sole witness and had not provided any material to prima facie demonstrate that the alleged imputation had lowered his reputation in others’ estimation.

“There is no material on record, in the form of a statement of any other person or otherwise, to prima facie demonstrate that the alleged imputation had the effect of lowering the reputation of Respondent No 2 (complainant) in the estimation of others.”The allegation that the publication caused damage to his reputation, by itself, remains an assertion of the complainant and does not establish the statutory requirement contemplated by Explanation 4 to Section 499 (defamation) of IPC,” the court said in its order passed on August 25.

The high court said permitting the criminal proceedings to continue would not advance the cause of justice and instead subject the petitioner (Misra) to the rigours of a criminal trial in the absence of sufficient foundational material.”Accordingly, this court deems it appropriate, in exercise of its jurisdiction under Section 482 of CrPC, to quash the impugned summoning order and the consequential proceedings arising therefrom. (PTI)

SC seeks Delhi Police reply on Athar Khan’s bail plea

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has sought a response from the Delhi Police on a plea filed by Athar Khan seeking bail in a case under the anti-terror law UAPA concerning the “larger conspiracy” behind the February 2020 riots in northeast Delhi.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi issued notice to police on an appeal filed by Khan challenging the Delhi High Court’s July 7 judgment refusing bail to him. “Issue notice. List after eight weeks,” the bench said. The high court

had dismissed Athar’s appeal challenging the trial court’s January 29 order that denied him relief in the case, stating that he was but “one of the main conspirators who conspired to cause deaths during the riots” and not a “mere local-level operator”.

Athar’s lawyer had sought bail because he was a “local-level facilitator” who had been in custody for six years, and that similarly placed co-accused had been granted bail by the Supreme Court. The HC bench had considered the Supreme Court’s findings on the bail pleas by the co-accused and held that Athar’s role was



Lokpal Must Act, Not Just Wait



PRASHANT TEWARI

An overstretched Government and overburdened courts in India need not carry the entire burden of clean governance alone. A properly empowered Lokpal can become a vital institutional partner-detecting corruption, initiating action, coordinating investigation and enabling specialised adjudication within the mandate for which Parliament created it. The objective is not to create another layer of Government or judicial power, but to make existing institutions work better. When the Lokpal is given the authority, independence and resources to act proactively, it can relieve administrative and judicial pressure, prevent public wrongdoing from festering, and help the State deliver services with greater integrity, efficiency and public trust. A Lokpal that is empowered to fulfil its mandate does not compete with Government or the courts; it strengthens both.

Corruption is not merely a financial offence; it is a systemic threat to the rule of law, public administration and democratic accountability. It diverts public resources, distorts markets, creates unequal access to State power and erodes citizens’ faith in constitutional Government. An effective anti-corruption framework must therefore do more than respond to complaints. It must be capable of detecting patterns of abuse, initiating timely inquiry, tracing illicit assets and ensuring that corruption cases reach specialised forums capable of deciding them expeditiously.

The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013 was intended to create precisely such an institutional mechanism. The Lokpal has jurisdiction over specified public functionaries and possesses statutory mechanisms relating to inquiry, investigation, search and seizure, asset attachment, prosecution and Special Courts. Yet the institution’s effectiveness depends not merely upon the powers written in the statute, but upon its capacity to activate them proactively. The principal reform should therefore be to give the Lokpal an expressly defined and carefully regulated suo motu jurisdiction.

Section 20 of the Lokpal Act is substantially structured around complaints received by the Lokpal and the subsequent decision to order preliminary inquiry or investigation. The provision also creates a functional relationship with the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC), including references for preliminary inquiry concerning different categories of public servants.

A complaint-driven architecture,

however, can be inadequate where corruption itself suppresses complaints. A subordinate officer may fear retaliation, a contractor may depend upon future Government contracts, and a beneficiary of an unlawful decision has little incentive to complain. Citizens may possess credible information without having access to the documentary material necessary to formulate a formal complaint.

Parliament should therefore amend Section 20 to expressly empower the Lokpal to initiate a preliminary inquiry on the basis of information received from any credible source or on its own assessment of material available to it. Such material could include audit findings, unexplained enrichment, suspicious procurement patterns, repeated irregularities, whistleblower disclosures, financial intelligence, credible investigative reporting, data analytics or information received from another statutory authority.

The power should not be unrestricted. A prima facie threshold, written reasons and authorisation by a multi-member Bench would ensure that proactive jurisdiction remains a legal power rather than an instrument of arbitrary investigation.

In fact, Karnataka provides a significant legislative precedent. The Karnataka Lokayukta Act was strengthened by the 2010 amendment to expressly enable the Lokayukta to initiate investigation suo motu, subject to recording an opinion in writing. The legislative objective was to make the institution more effective.

The national Lokpal can build upon this experience. The principle is simple: where corruption is concealed by its very nature, requiring a formal complainant to activate the institution can defeat the purpose of anti-corruption law. An even more important judicial analogy comes from environmental law. In Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai v. Ankita Sinha (2021), the Supreme Court held that the National Green Tribunal possesses suo motu power in discharge of its statutory functions. The Court recognised the NGT’s role as a specialised institution created to address environmental harm and accepted that its jurisdiction could be activated without waiting for a conventional application where the statutory conditions were satisfied.

The judgment must not be mechanically transplanted into the Lokpal framework: the NGT’s jurisdiction flows from its specific statute. Its significance lies instead in the institutional principle it illustrates. A specialised statutory body created to protect an important public interest may require the ability to act upon credible information rather than remain passive until a formal litigant appears.

The analogy is compelling. Environmental damage may become irreversible if intervention is delayed; corruption similarly becomes harder to prosecute once records disappear,



witnesses are influenced and illicit assets are transferred. Proactive jurisdiction is therefore not an expansion of power for its own sake-it can be a condition of effective statutory enforcement. At the same time, Ankita Sinha reinforces the proposition that suo motu power cannot mean unregulated power. Natural justice, fairness and judicial review must remain the controlling safeguards.

A stronger Lokpal should not become a substitute for the judiciary or every investigative agency. India instead needs a coherent division of institutional labour. The Lokpal should detect and inquire into corruption falling within its statutory jurisdiction, coordinate investigation, facilitate prosecution and ensure that cases proceed before competent Special Courts. Special Courts should undertake speedy factual adjudication and develop expertise in procurement fraud, disproportionate assets, abuse of office, shell-company structures and complex financial transactions.

The Supreme Court, meanwhile, should remain principally concerned with constitutional interpretation, fundamental rights, questions of national legal significance and authoritative settlement of law. Where a corruption matter before the Court essentially requires extensive factual investigation, the Court should, wherever constitutionally and statutorily permissible, utilise the specialised statutory architecture rather than becoming the primary fact-finding forum. This would not diminish judicial power. It would strengthen constitutional governance through institutional competence: the Lokpal investigates, Special Courts adjudicate, and constitutional courts ensure legality and protect constitutional rights.

Integrating Lokpal and CVC can resolve many issues. The existing statutory relationship between the Lokpal and CVC also warrants reform. Section 20 already permits the Lokpal to refer complaints concerning different categories of public servants to the CVC for preliminary inquiry. This demonstrates that Parliament itself recognised the need for functional coordination.

The next step should be a more coherent statutory architecture.

Parliament could integrate the CVC’s anti-corruption investigative and vigilance functions within an overall framework strategically supervised by the Lokpal, while preserving the CVC’s legitimate vigilance-administration role and appropriate functional autonomy. Such integration would require amendments to both the Lokpal Act and the CVC Act; it should not be achieved through executive instructions alone. The objective should be to eliminate duplication, establish clear jurisdiction, share intelligence and infrastructure, strengthen financial investigation and create a defined chain of institutional accountability.

Modern corruption rarely ends with the original bribe. It may involve layered transactions, shell companies, benami holdings, manipulated procurement and transfers across jurisdictions. The Lokpal must therefore develop the institutional capacity to follow the money.

Subject to statutory safeguards, it should have effective mechanisms to access relevant financial and Governmental information and coordinate with competent agencies for tracing, attachment, confiscation and recovery of illicit assets. The objective should be preventive as well as punitive: corrupt proceeds should be secured before they can be dissipated.

A powerful Lokpal must also be an accountable Lokpal. Suo motu jurisdiction should consequently be accompanied by certain guidelines: The exercise of suo motu jurisdiction must be accompanied by strong procedural and constitutional safeguards to ensure that proactive power does not become arbitrary power. The Lokpal should be required to act only upon a prima facie credible threshold of material, record written reasons for initiating proceedings, and obtain authorisation from a multi-member Bench.

Preliminary scrutiny should ordinarily remain confidential to protect both the integrity of the investigation and the reputation of persons against whom allegations are made, while robust whistleblower protection should encourage the disclosure of genuine wrongdoing. At every stage, the Lokpal must remain bound by natural justice, including an effective opportunity of hearing before adverse findings or consequences are made.

quential orders are made. Its decisions should remain subject to judicial review, while periodic reporting to Parliament would ensure democratic accountability and institutional transparency. Equally important, the framework should provide mechanisms for the prompt closure of proceedings where allegations are unsupported by sufficient material, coupled with appropriate consequences for deliberately false, malicious or vexatious proceedings. Such safeguards would ensure that the Lokpal is powerful enough to act decisively against corruption, yet sufficiently restrained to remain faithful to the rule of law.

These safeguards embody the constitutional balance: the State must possess sufficient power to investigate corruption, but sufficient restraint to prevent anti-corruption powers from becoming instruments of harassment. India does not need a Lokpal that merely waits for complaints. It needs an institution capable of identifying credible signals of corruption and acting before public resources disappear, evidence is compromised and illicit wealth is transferred beyond recovery.

The Karnataka experience demonstrates that suo motu anti-corruption jurisdiction can be created legislatively with safeguards. Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai v. Ankita Sinha demonstrates, in the distinct environmental context, the constitutional value of enabling a specialised statutory institution to act proactively within its jurisdiction.

The reform agenda should therefore be clear: express suo motu jurisdiction for the Lokpal; integrated anti-corruption intelligence; stronger coordination with the CVC and investigative agencies; specialised financial-investigation capacity; effective asset recovery; empowered Special Courts; whistleblower protection; and robust judicial safeguards.

The objective is neither an all-powerful Lokpal nor a passive ombudsman. It is an independent, proactive, specialised and constitutionally disciplined Lokpal. A powerful Lokpal would not compete with the Government or constitutional courts. It would assist both. It would help the executive identify institutional corruption, enable specialised courts to deliver speedy justice and allow the Supreme Court to devote its extraordinary constitutional jurisdiction to questions that genuinely require its intervention.

Clean governance requires more than laws against corruption. It requires institutions capable of enforcing those laws before corruption becomes irreversible. The Lokpal should become that institution: proactive enough to detect abuse, powerful enough to investigate it, specialised enough to secure prosecution, and accountable enough to remain faithful to the Constitution.

The author is a public policy expert and columnist

SC to hear plea against cash donations to parties on August 31

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on August 31 a plea which has challenged the validity of a provision of the Income Tax Act that allows political parties to receive cash donations below ₹2,000.

According to the apex court’s cause list of August 31, the plea would come up for hearing before a bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta.

On November 24 last year, the top court had agreed to hear the petition and sought responses from the Centre and others on it.

The plea claimed that lack of transparency undermines the purity of the election process as it deprives voters of the crucial knowledge about the source of political funding,

including the donors and their motives, preventing them from making a rational, intelligent and fully informed decision while casting their vote.

The petition, filed by Khem Singh Bhati, also sought a direction to the poll panel to prescribe as a condition for registration of a political party and allotment of the election symbol that no amount can be received in cash by any political party.

The plea sought the striking down of Clause (d) of Section 13A of the Income Tax Act, 1961, as unconstitutional and also referred to the apex court’s 2024 judgement which scrapped the electoral bonds scheme.

Section 13A of the Act deals with the special provision relating to the incomes of political parties.

“The petitioner is seeking



direction that the political parties must disclose the name and all other particulars of the person paying any amount of money to it, and no amount can be received in cash to maintain transparency in the political funding,” the plea said. It said Section 13A was

introduced in the Act and income of a political party received by way of interest on securities, income from house property or income from other sources and any income by way of voluntary contributions are exempted from the computation of total income.

PIONEER NEW SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Alleged conman Sukesh Chandrasekhar has moved the Delhi High Court against a trial court decision convicting him for impersonating a Supreme Court judge to influence a special judge for bail in a 2017 corruption case.

Chandrasekhar has sought the deletion of the “derogatory, pejorative, stigmatised and unnecessary observations” on his character in the trial court’s judgment. He has said in his plea that the trial court has repeatedly characterised him in terms that are “wholly unnecessary for adjudication”.

Chandrasekhar has asserted that the trial court’s judgment is contrary to the fundamental requirement that a case must be adjudicated upon evidence and not on an assumed character of the accused.

The trial court approached the case with a “predetermined and adverse mindset” and denied him the opportunity to complete defence evidence, the plea has said.

The case arose from a phone call made on April 28, 2017, when Chandrasekhar was in police custody in connection with the corruption case. According to the prosecution, he obtained access to



the mobile phone of police constable Manjeet and used it to contact the official landline and mobile phone of Poonam Chaudhary, then a special

judge dealing with Prevention of Corruption Act cases.

On August 20, the trial court held Chandrasekhar guilty of the offences under Indian Penal Code sections 170 (personating a public servant), 189 (threat of injury to a public servant) and 507 (criminal intimidation by an anonymous communication), and described his crime as a “direct affront” to the independence and sanctity of the judicial process.

The trial court said Chandrasekhar had first impersonated the private secretary of a then Supreme Court judge and later, the judge himself.

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BUSINESS11

Tata Power commissions solar project in Rajasthan

Tata Power Renewable Energy on Thursday announced the commissioning of a 72.5-megawatt solar project at Bikaner in Rajasthan.

The energy will be supplied to Tata Steel through TP Vardhman Surya, a subsidiary of Tata Power Renewable Energy Limited (TPREL), a statement said.

TPREL said the ground-mounted project is expected to generate 166 MUs of green energy annually, and offset 1,18,856 tonnes of carbon emissions annually. The project deploys 1,71,360 modules for the Tata Steel project that have been manufactured from TP Solar Limited. "The project is advancing Tata Steel's decarbonisation journey and strengthening TPREL's contribution to India's renewable energy capacity," it said.

With the addition of this project, TPREL's total renewable utility capacity has reached 12.3 GW.

Out of this, around 7 GW (5.7 GW of solar and 1.3 GW of wind) is operational, while close to 5.3 GW is under various stages of implementation, which includes 2.2 GW of solar and 3.1 GW of wind. Tata Power Renewable Energy is a subsidiary of Tata Power Company.

(PTI)

SEBI mulls scrapping merchant banker rule for small-ticket debt

Markets regulator Sebi on Thursday proposed granting an exemption from mandatory appointment of a merchant banker for small-value debt issued through a private placement basis by listed entities.

The move is aimed at reducing compliance costs and boosting market development.

The current rule requires issuers to appoint at least one merchant banker for private placements of debt securities or non-convertible redeemable preference shares with a face value of ₹10,000.

This increases the cost of capital for issuers, eroding the economic viability of planned issuances, thereby discouraging frequent small-value debt issuances, Sebi said in its consultation paper.

Accordingly, Sebi has proposed to exempt "small-value debt" issues from the requirement to appoint merchant bankers.~

(PTI)

BPCL says no decision to replace E20 with E10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Bharat Petroleum Corp Ltd (BPCL), India's second largest fuel retailer, on Thursday said there is no decision to replace E20 petrol with E10, clarifying that the current debate is over whether older vehicles should have access to a lower-ethanol blend and how an additional grade of petrol could be supplied across India's vast fuel-distribution network.

In a media call post the company's annual shareholder meeting, BPCL Chairman and Managing Director Sanjay Khanna, however, said he saw no operational or logistical chal-

lenge in switching from E20 petrol to E10 if the government decides to change the ethanol-blending policy.

"I never said that E20 will

be changed to E10," he said, adding that it was being debated in some circles whether older vehicles should have an option of

lower-ethanol blend fuel.

"That doesn't mean E20 will be out and E10 will be in," he said. His comments come amid a wider policy discussion over whether owners of older vehicles should have access to E10 petrol, which contains 10 per cent ethanol, alongside E20, which contains 20 per cent ethanol. India has progressively increased ethanol blending in petrol as part of efforts to reduce crude oil imports, lower emissions and support domestic ethanol production.

Khanna stressed that no decision has been finalised on changing the current fuel-blending regime.

"Nothing has been finalised," he said. "But to

answer your question, what if it happens or what are the changes required? I will say nothing because already we established E20. It's only a matter of changing from E20 to E10, or suppose it has to be done. On that account, we don't see as a company any challenge for that matter. None of the oil companies will have a challenge to go from E20 to E10."

It is being debated whether India should make E10 petrol, which contains 10 per cent ethanol, available alongside E20 fuel, following concerns raised by some consumers and industry stakeholders about the impact of higher ethanol blends on vehicles and fuel availability.

India's EV market to reach ₹20 lakh crore by 2030: Gadkari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

India's electric vehicle (EV) market is expected to grow to ₹20 lakh crore by 2030, with the potential to create five crore jobs, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday.

Addressing a summit organised by the CII-ITC Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Development, Gadkari said that currently 57 lakh electric vehicles are registered in India, with 7 per cent market penetration.

"India's electric vehicle (EV) market will be worth ₹20 lakh crore by 2030. It will also create five crore jobs by 2030," he said.

The road transport and highways minister highlighted that India's two largest two-wheeler vehicle manu-

facturers, Bajaj Auto and Hero MotoCorp, export more than 50 per cent of vehicles they produce. Gadkari said there is demand for one lakh electric buses annually in India, but 'we are able to manufacture only 50,000-60,000 EV buses annually'.

He said the government aims to make India's automobile industry number

one in the world within five years. The future of the Indian automobile industry is very good as the country has trained manpower, Gadkari added. "Within five years, our target is to make India's automobile industry the number 1 in the world... it is difficult, but not impossible," the minister said.

Gadkari pointed out that

the quality of vehicles manufactured in India is good and the cost is less, so all top automobile companies are present in the country.

"When I took charge as transport minister, the size of the Indian automobile industry was ₹14 lakh crore. The size of the Indian automobile industry is now ₹22 lakh crore," Gadkari said.

Presently, the size of the US automobile industry is ₹78 lakh crore, followed by China (₹47 lakh crore) and India (₹23 lakh crore).

Gadkari noted that India is spending ₹22 lakh crore on importing fossil fuels and because of the import of fossil fuels, "we are facing a problem of pollution".

"We are making good highways. Good roads with alternatives, and bio-fuel is the future," the minister said.

Gold extends slide, falls ₹800 ahead of Rakshabandhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Gold prices fell for the second straight session, declining by ₹800 to ₹1,65,700 per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday, even as local markets geared up for Rakshabandhan celebrations.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at ₹1,66,500 per 10 grams on Wednesday.

However, silver remained unchanged at ₹2,50,500 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes), according to local traders. The decline in gold comes a day before Rakshabandhan, when consumers traditionally step up purchases of gifts and jewellery. The festival, to be celebrated on Friday, is marked by the exchange of gifts between brothers and sisters, with gold and silver jewellery contributing significantly to festive purchases.

Analysts said gold prices also fell due to a rebound in the US dollar and Treasury bond yields.

Spot gold traded lower on Thursday

as a recovery in the US dollar and Treasury yields weighed on the yellow metal following stronger-than-expected US inflation data, Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst of Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

Gold declined ₹1,400 over the last two

trading sessions, after touching ₹1,67,100 per 10 grams on Tuesday.

Akshat Siddhant, Lead Quant Analyst at investment platform Mudrex, said silver remained steady after its initial sell-off in the local markets.

Market participants are also keeping an eye on the US Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh's Jackson Hole speech on Friday, he said.

Analysts said that any signal on the Fed's approach to inflation and interest rates could influence the dollar and Treasury yields, which in turn affect the appeal of assets such as gold.

Globally, spot gold slipped marginally to trade at \$ 4,585.88 per ounce.

Spot gold prices traded lower as the US dollar index firmed up on inflation data, as Fed rate hike probability increased, Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said. Silver, however, showed greater resilience in the overseas markets, rising 0.31 per cent to \$68.32 per ounce.

Rupee falls 11 paise to close at 95.55 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day lower by 11 paise at 95.55 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, on a strong American currency and weak domestic markets.

Forex traders said the broad strength of the American currency in the overseas market negated the support from easing crude oil prices.

Brent prices fell below the \$90 mark for the first time in several sessions amid continuing discussions between Iran and Oman regarding a

temporary shipping corridor through the Strait.

While no final agreement has been reached, the fact that negotiations are continuing has reduced fears of a prolonged disruption to global oil supplies, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.50, then touched an intraday high of 95.40 and a low of 95.56 and finally settled for the day at 95.55 (provisional) against the greenback, lower by 11 paise from its previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee settled for the day higher by 26 paise at 95.44 against

the US dollar. The Indian foreign exchange market was closed on Wednesday on account of Id-e-Milad.

According to forex traders, market participants will be closely monitoring US Fed Chair Kevin Warsh's speech at the Jackson Hole Symposium.

According to Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, the rupee's story this month is really the story of the flows.

"The special swap facility has attracted total inflows of nearly \$73 billion as of August 21, over \$65 billion through

FCNR(B) deposits alone, roughly two-and-a-half times what the celebrated 2013 scheme raised, and with the final rush into the August 31 deposit deadline and the ECB window open until December, we estimate total flows under these schemes could touch \$85 to \$90 billion," Banerjee said.

The inflows have created a formidable war-chest, and it means the rupee's appreciation potential remains largely unspent, he said, adding, "We expect a 95 to 96 operational range, and a close below 95 would open a move towards 94. We remain bullish on the Indian

rupee." Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.21, higher by 0.05 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 0.61 per cent at \$88.38 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic market front, Sensex fell 539.35 points to settle at 76,933.59, while the Nifty dropped 116.90 points to 24,090.85.

Foreign institutional investors purchased equities worth ₹502.63 crore on a net basis on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

NTPC aims 244 GW operational capacity, ₹16.86 lakh crore capex by 2037: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

NTPC expects to build 244 gigawatts of operating capacity and envisage capital expenditure of ₹16.86 lakh crore by 2037 as it looks to boost the entire energy value chain, the company's Chairman Gurdeep Singh said on Thursday.

The next decade will be one of the most significant periods of growth in NTPC's history, Singh said, noting India's electricity requirement will continue to rise as the economy expands and living standards improve.

At the same time, the composition of the power system will change rapidly, he said while addressing the shareholders at the company's 50th Annual General Meeting (AGM). "We have raised our long-

term capacity ambitions and now target generating capacity of 149 GW by 2032, including 60 GW of renewable energy, with an aspiration to reach 244 GW by 2037 excluding storage," Singh said.

NABARD, NaBFID sign MoU for funding rural infra projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development and the National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development have signed an initial pact to strengthen collaboration in financing infrastructure projects with significant rural impact.

The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) provides a framework for joint financing, knowledge sharing and the development of innovative financing solutions, with a focus on expanding

access to long-term, competitively priced finance for projects that can strengthen rural infrastructure and value chains, a joint statement said on Thursday.

GAIL plans major expansion in gas, petrochemicals and clean energy, says chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

State-run gas utility GAIL (India) Ltd plans to expand its natural gas pipeline network, diversify LNG sourcing and shipping, scale up petrochemicals and LPG infrastructure, and invest in clean-energy technologies as geopolitical disruptions underscore the need for greater energy security, the company's chairman said on Thursday.

Addressing GAIL's 42nd annual general meeting, Deepak Gupta said the year had highlighted the growing importance of bal-

ancing energy security with the global shift toward cleaner fuels.

"Energy security has become as important as energy transition," he said, pointing to geopolitical tensions in the Middle East and disruptions to LNG supply chains through the Strait of Hormuz that exposed vulnerabilities in global energy markets.

"The resulting volatility in LNG prices, freight rates and supply availability reinforced the need for diversified sourcing, resilient infrastructure and flexible supply chains," he said. "At the same time, the global transition

towards cleaner energy continued unabated, with sustained investments in renewable energy, nuclear power, energy storage and low-carbon technologies."

Natural gas, because of its flexibility and lower

carbon intensity, would continue to play a role in the energy transition, he said.

Gupta said the company's pipeline network, already India's largest natural gas transmission system, has expanded to more than

18,690 kilometres, with another 1,500 km under construction. Once those projects are completed, the network is expected to approach 20,000 km.

GAIL is simultaneously expanding its LPG transmission business. The company is doubling the capacity of its 1,427-km Jamnagar-Loni LPG pipeline to 6.5 MMTA from 3.25 MMTA.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board has also authorised GAIL to develop three LPG pipelines with a combined length of about 1,775 km.

In petrochemicals, GAIL commissioned a 60,000-

tonne-a-year polypropylene unit at Pata, raising the integrated complex's capacity to 870,000 tonnes from 810,000 tonnes.

The company is also progressing with its 500,000-tonne-a-year propane dehydrogenation-polypropylene project at Usar, which Gupta described as India's first PDH-based polypropylene complex. The project entails an estimated investment of about ₹11,256 crore.

At Mangalore, work is progressing on a 1.25 MMTA purified terephthalic acid (PTA) plant, giving GAIL an entry into another petrochemical value chain.

FROM THE WORLD

MALAYSIA

Former PM faces charges

Malaysian former Prime Minister Ismail Sabri Yaakob was charged Thursday with failing to declare his assets, making him the nation's third leader to face criminal charges after leaving office.

Ismail, 66, pleaded not guilty to a charge under the anti-graft law that alleged he failed to provide a complete declaration of assets following a notice from the anti-corruption agency in January 225. The charge sheet lists large amounts of cash in Malaysian and foreign currencies, as well as gold and silver.

If convicted, Ismail faces up to five years' imprisonment and a fine. Ismail, the country's ninth leader, unexpectedly became prime minister without a general election after emerging as a consensus figure during a turbulent political period.

Muhyiddin Yassin, who was the eight prime minister, is currently on trial over corruption and money-laundering charge.

NORWAY

King Harald critically ill

Norwegian King Harald was in "very serious condition" as his health deteriorated, palace officials said on Thursday, prompting the queen and Crown Prince Haakon to cancel their engagements.

The 89-year-old monarch, who has hemolytic anemia and has been on sick leave for several weeks, was admitted to the National Hospital in Oslo earlier this month. His condition had previously stabilised following a bacterial blood infection but the royal palace on Thursday said it had worsened.

Haakon, his son, has been serving as regent during the king's time in the hospital.

Harald, who has been monarch since 1991, has been in and out of the hospital several times in recent years. In February, he was admitted to a hospital in Spain's Canary Islands during a winter vacation for treatment for a skin infection.

Regional powers seek off-ramp from West Asia war

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Jerusalem

Qatar and other regional powers sought an off-ramp from the war with Iran as another tanker attack was reported in the Strait of Hormuz, and the Iranian Government dismissed the Trump administration's latest sanctions.

Elsewhere in the West Asia, a Jerusalem court acquitted a man accused of beating a Catholic nun, but ordered him to undergo years of psychiatric hospitalisation over the attack, which drew global condemnation.

Israel's strikes in Gaza drew a sharp rebuke from the top diplomat overseeing the US-brokered ceasefire in the territory. Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani was in Tehran on Thursday as part of Qatar's ongoing efforts



A pro-Govt demonstrator chants slogan during a gathering in a square in Tehran

to resolve the conflict between the United States and Iran.

Qatar's foreign ministry said in a post on X that the meeting with

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi included talks on "the efforts being made to reduce escalation," as well as a proposed plan

UK offers £5 million funds, emergency responders to Nepal



British PM Andy Burnham

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The UK on Thursday offered 5 million pounds and emergency responders to Nepal after flash floods in the country claimed hundreds of lives and left over a thousand missing, including around 33 British Nationals.

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham described the scenes emerging from the region as "devastating" and urged British Nationals caught up in the crisis to follow guidance from the local authorities.

He said immediate action already taken by the UK includes deploying consular support staff to the impacted area to facilitate round-the-clock support for British nationals. "It's a devastating picture that is emerging from what has happened in Nepal," Burnham told reporters during a visit to South Wales.

"An offer has been made of emergency responders to head to the region, but that's obviously a matter for the Nepalese Government. But also we've offered 5 million pounds to help with that response effort.

"Obviously, there are a number of British nationals who currently are thought to be missing and we'll be providing all the support we can to their families in what is a very distressing and devastating situation," he said.

The UK Foreign,

Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) said it is looking to provide humanitarian support following a request by the Nepali Government for food, shelter and health services.

However, it indicated that comprehensive humanitarian assessments are likely to take some time due to the scale of the damage. "I spoke to the Nepali Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal this morning [Thursday] and expressed Britain's solidarity and deepest condolences for the disaster that has occurred," said Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband.

"I thanked him for the efforts of the Nepali Government in support of British nationals in the area. I also offered financial, search and rescue and other help to aid the disaster response. Above all, I told him we will do everything we can to help Nepal in its hour of need," he said.

The Foreign Office said it is engaging with development partners, donors and international allies on a coordinated response activity in the region following the natural disaster, which caused massive landslides.

Global funds, to which the UK contributes, are said to be already disbursing funds to support the humanitarian response, such as the IFRC Disaster Relief Emergency Fund.

Chinese premier Li visits flood-affected area in Tibet

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Chinese Premier Li Qiang on Thursday visited the Gyirong Township near the Nepal border post in Tibet, where 36 people were reported missing after a massive flash flood that caused heavy casualties.

The flash flood struck the Gyirong Township in the Tibet Autonomous Region on Wednesday morning. It swept through villages and towns near the China-Nepal border area killing three in Tibet and 27 in Nepal, and leaving hundreds others missing. Li led a group of senior officials from relevant departments to the disaster-hit area, state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

The officials will supervise rescue and relief operations, and visit those affected by the disaster.

A directing group of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) Western Theatre Command, which looks



after the India-China border in Tibet, was dispatched to the affected area on Thursday to coordinate joint rescue operations by military personnel in Gyirong County.

Meanwhile, preliminary information released by local authorities showed that 26 foreign nationals were currently missing in the area,

believes his country is "winning very big."

Oil tanker attacked in Strait of Hormuz

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Organisation said on Thursday that it had received a report of an oil tanker hit in the Strait of Hormuz.

The monitoring agency, run by the British military, said that local authorities reported that the vessel was hit by an unknown projectile on Tuesday in the waters between Oman and Iran, causing it to catch fire. The crew was reported to be safe and there have been no reports of environmental damage, the UKMTO said.

Ensmail Baghaei, Iran's foreign ministry spokesman, wrote late Wednesday in a social media post



cles that had stalled in flooded roads were abandoned.

In neighbouring Ishikawa prefecture, west of Toyama, 27 homes in three municipalities were isolated due to flooding, though officials said there were no reports of injuries among the stranded residents.

Heavy rain also triggered landslides and closed roads in Ishikawa.

Chief Cabinet Secretary Minoru

Kihara said several rivers overflowed in the two prefectures, flooding many homes without reported injuries. The severe weather caused power outages at more than 1, homes in Toyama and Ishikawa, according to the Hokuriku Electric Power Co.

Heavy rain and widespread flooding earlier this month in the Chiba prefecture, east of Tokyo, left 13 people dead.

that the US had made a coalition with Bahrain, calling it a country with "virtually no meaningful economic exchange with Iran."

In another social media post on Wednesday, Iran's top negotiator and parliamentary speaker Bagher Ghalibaf thanked China for rejecting the US "economic D-Day" policies against Iran.

"We welcome China's principled statement rejecting illegal sanctions against Iran," Ghalibaf said. Earlier this week, Tehran had warned that it would respond harshly to expanded US sanctions, including measures against countries it sees as cooperating with Washington. Iran has repeatedly targeted Bahrain and other Gulf countries with missiles and drones since the US and Israel launched the war on February 28.

with Nepalese authorities.

Lin said China is maintaining close communication and coordination with Nepal and working with the Nepalese side on the search and rescue operations.

Due to the impact of the disaster, more detailed information was still being awaited, he added.

On Wednesday, Chinese President Xi Jinping ordered all-out search and rescue efforts. Following this, the directing group of the PLA Western Theatre Command was dispatched to the affected area.

Carried by the Y-2 transport aircraft, the group will organise military forces to assist in disaster relief efforts, Xinhua reported.

The command mobilised multiple rescue forces to the affected area to assist road clearance, disaster assessment, search and rescue operations, and relocation of affected residents.

SOUTH KOREA POLICE SEEK INDICTMENT OF 7 OVER JEJU AIR CRASH

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Seoul

South Korea's police said Thursday they were seeking indictments of seven transport ministry officials over the 224 Jeju Air crash that killed all but two of the 181 people on board.

The Boeing 737-8 operated by Jeju Air skidded off the runway at Muan International Airport in southern South Korea after its landing gear failed to deploy, slamming into a concrete structure and bursting into flames.

Authorities have found traces of bird strike in the plane's engines and the plane's two black boxes stopped recording about four minutes before the crash.

PUBLIC NOTICE

General public is hereby informed that my clients Ram Babu S/o Dalip Singh and Dakshini W/o Ram Babu R/o A-186 Mangol Puri, Delhi-110083, have entirely broken all their relations with them Ravi Baghel and his wife Shivani (Radhika) and my aforesaid clients have also disowned and defebared their said son and daughter in law from all her movable & immovable properties. Anybody dealing with Ravi Baghel and Shivani (Radhika) will do so at his/her/their own risk and responsibilities and my clients shall not be responsible for any act, deed or dealing done by Ram Babu or his wife Dakshini.

Sanjeev Dwivedi (Advocate)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Kanwar Pal is the owner of A Residential Nigam Plot No. 253/3, area measuring 245.88 sq. yds. (3X17.7m, mtr) Pat. No. 129 Situated at Jawahar Nagar Rohta Road Tehsil & Distt. Meerut (U.P.) Same is owned by Sale Deed dated 20.08.2015, Doc No: 5115, Executed by Mrs. Khatto W/o Late Mr. Desamant in favour of Mr. Kanwar Pal S/o Mr. Nain Singh duly registered in the office of the sub registrar-IV Meerut vide Doc. No.5115, Book No. 1, Vol. No. 4859, Page No. 75-116. That all persons are hereby informed that Mr. Kanwar Pal is mortgaging the said property with PIRAMAL FINANCE LTD. General public hereby informed that if Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present date. **Medhaswini Enforcement & Legal Service** 329, Aditya Palace Garh Road Meerut U.P. 250004, Mob no: 720601626, 9818171624 Email: medhaswienforcement@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Sh. Manish Sharma is the possessor of the Property Bearing No. AE-42, (Plot No. E-42, in Block-A), 83, Kharsa No. 54/1/2, Situated at Village- Hasthal, Delhi Colony Known as Vidya Vihar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi. They are in possession through GPA, 475, W.L. dated 06.04.2024 executed by Mr. Ashok Tiyaag in favour of 1. Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur in respect of Plot No. 83, area measuring 150 Sq. Yds. Thereafter, Authorization Slip dated 11.09.2024 as doc. no. 2024265/24762 executed by Mr. Ashok Tiyaag (Pdt Uday) in favour of Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur in respect of Regn. No. 1484, Built-up Property Bearing Plot No. 83, Kharsa No. 54/1/2. Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur intends to transfer the ownership of Second Floor (Without Roof Right) of above said Property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Bibek Saha. Subsequently, Mr. Bibek Saha is in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 10-days period by contacting Lucem Legal LLP (North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, Landline: +9112-40498711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Sh. Manish Sharma is the possessor of the Property Bearing No. AE-42, (Plot No. E-42, in Block-A), 83, Kharsa No. 54/1/2, Situated at Village- Hasthal, Delhi Colony Known as Vidya Vihar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi. They are in possession through GPA, 475, W.L. dated 06.04.2024 executed by Mr. Ashok Tiyaag in favour of 1. Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur in respect of Plot No. 83, area measuring 150 Sq. Yds. Thereafter, Authorization Slip dated 11.09.2024 as doc. no. 2024265/24762 executed by Mr. Ashok Tiyaag (Pdt Uday) in favour of Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur in respect of Regn. No. 1484, Built-up Property Bearing Plot No. 83, Kharsa No. 54/1/2. Mrs. Kancharan Rani and Mrs. Sattinder Kaur intends to transfer the ownership of Second Floor (Without Roof Right) of above said Property by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Bibek Saha. Subsequently, Mr. Bibek Saha is in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

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PUBLIC NOTICE

This notice is given on behalf of Mr. Pawan to inform the public that Mrs. Sangeta and Mr. Jagdish are the owners of Property no.1-V, measuring 137 sq. yds, Kharsa no. 67 situated at Village Saboli, Abadi of Lal Dora, New Mandoli Industrial area, Phase-1, Illaga Shahdara Delhi-110093 through Relinquishment Deed dated 12.05.2026 (Doc. No.2026/23/5902) executed by Mrs. Mukesh. The same is to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Capital Ltd., Branch-Noida. That, Mr. Part Pal was the owner of the property through Regd. GPA (Doc. No.612), Agreement to Sell & Will dated 08-04-2015. Further, Mr. Part Pal @ Prati Pal expired on 14.05.2021 leaving behind his legal heirs namely (i) Mr. Pawan (ii) Mr. Jagdish (Sons) (iii) Mrs. Mukesh (Wife) but Surviving Member Certificate of Late Mr. Part Pal @ Prati Palis not available. To comply with BANK/NBFC requirements, any person having any claim/right/title/interest/mortgage over the said property may submit their objections in writing to the address below within 7 days from today. Failing this, the property shall be presumed free from all encumbrances, liens, etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-408, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida, UP-201301 Contact# 0120-4269379

ADMISSION NOTICE

B.R.M.T. College of Education (Old Khaira Road, Prem Nagar, Najafgarh New Delhi-43) invites application for management quota seats in D.El.Ed & DPSE courses for session **2026-2028**. The candidates can collect their application forms from the office between 9:30am to 4:00pm. Application may be submitted in the college from **27-08-2026 to 10-09-2026**. Admission process will be as per SCERT guidelines. List will be displayed on 12th September 2026 on www.brmtcollege.in & college notice board. Contact No. 8851893977

ADMISSION NOTICE

Aaryan College of Education, Om Vihar, Uttam Nagar, Near West Metro Station, New Delhi-59 invites application for management quota seats in D.El.Ed & DPSE courses for session **2026-2028**. The candidates can collect their application form from the office between 9:30am to 4:00pm. Application may be submitted in the college from **27-08-2026 to 10-09-2026**. Admission process will be as per SCERT guidelines. List will be displayed on 12th September 2026 on www.aaryancollege.org & college notice board. Contact No. 8130643394

ADMISSION NOTICE

Aaryan College of Education, Om Vihar, Uttam Nagar, Near West Metro Station, New Delhi-59 invites application for management quota seats in D.El.Ed & DPSE courses for session **2026-2028**. The candidates can collect their application form from the office between 9:30am to 4:00pm. Application may be submitted in the college from **27-08-2026 to 10-09-2026**. Admission process will be as per SCERT guidelines. List will be displayed on 12th September 2026 on www.aaryancollege.org & college notice board. Contact No. 8130643394

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the Certificates for the undermentioned securities of the company have been lost/misplaced and the holders/Claimants of the said securities/applicants have applied to the Company to issue duplicate Certificates. Any person who has claim in respect of the said securities should lodge such claim with the Company at its Registered Office within 15 days from the newspaper notification date, else the Company will proceed to issue duplicate certificates without further intimation and no claim will lie thereafter.Shareholder: Late Smt. Didar Kaur Arora; Type: Equity with Face Value - Rs.10/-; Folio: 0000514; Total No. of Shares: 190 ; Certificate No : 38425 (Distinctive No - 2877255 - 2 8 7 7 2 7 9) , Certificate No : 335323(Distinctive No - 13546981 - 13547000), Certificate No. : 335322 (Distinctive No - 13546931 - 13546980), Certificate No:204983 (Distinctive No - 6385736 - 6385775), Certificate No: 16687 (Distinctive No - 2179809 - 2179858), CertificateNo: 38426 (Distinctive No - 2877280-2877284)

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Mohammad Latif Khan, S/o Abdul Wahid Khan, R/o. R- 109, Gali No.7, Jogabai Extension, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have declared that my name was wrongly mentioned in my son Mohammad Anas Madni's documents as Mohammad Lateef Khan instead of my correct name Mohammad Latif Khan.

I Aarushi Ashok Karwa S/O Ashok Karwa R/O 195, Tagore Park, Delhi-110009 have changed my name to Aarushi Karwa.

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Website : www.mprdc.gov.in, CIN : U45203MP2004SGC016758
NIT No.716/MPRDC/Procu/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation Limited (MPRDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works :-

S. No.	Name of Work	APC/ PAC Value (in INR Crore)	Bid Security (EMD) (in INR Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document (i/c GST) (in Rs.)	Period of Contract/ Completion
1.	User Fee Collection on Bhopal Bypass Road in the State of Madhya Pradesh.	79.35	396.75	59,000/-	24 Months
2.	User Fee Collection on Khalghat-Manawar Road in the State of Madhya Pradesh.	22.42	112.10	59,000/-	24 Months
3.	User Fee Collection on Udaipura-Gadarwara Road in the State of Madhya Pradesh.	3.09	15.45	17,700/-	24 Months
4.	B.T. Renewal work at Pipariya-Matkuli SH-62 (Km. 109-114, 116, 117) and Matkuli-Pachmadhi SH-41A (km. 24 to 28) road Total length - 13.00 km. (3rd Call)	3.05	3.05	17,700/-	03 Months (Excluding Rainy Seasons)
5.	Repair of Road surface at narwar City Portion (Km 63 and 64) on Dabra-Bhitarwar-Harsi-Narwar Road (Total Length 1400m).	2.90	2.90	17,700/-	6 Months (including rainy season)
6.	Operation of the canteen in the office of MPRDC, Bhopal.	0.036	0.072	2,360/-	24 Months

The Dates for purchase, submission, etc. are mentioned in the key dates. Tender forms can be purchased online only upto **15:30 hrs. on 06.10.2026 for Sr. No. 1 to 3, 5 & 6 and 24.09.2026 for Sr. No. 4 from website www.mptenders.gov.in**. The bidders have to submit the Technical bid as well as Financial Bid online only. The Addendum/Corrigendum (if any) shall only be published on the website of www.mptenders.gov.in only. If holiday is declared by Govt. of M.P. on the date of opening, the same will automatically be shifted to subsequent working days. MPRDC reserves the right to accept/reject any/all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

M.P. Madhyam/127804/2026

MANAGING DIRECTOR

Meta platforms reaches \$18b settlement with 48 US States

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Oakland

Kids under 18 will soon see a host of changes to their Instagram and Facebook experiences thanks to a historic \$18 billion settlement Meta Platforms reached Wednesday with 48 US states. Besides the money, which will be paid out over a decade, Meta has agreed to strengthen its age estimates to keep kids under 13 off its platforms and teens in age-appropriate accounts, enact a hard limit of two hours a day for users under 18, block kids from the apps from midnight to 6 am, and hide “like” counts, among other changes.

While acknowledging the changes go further than Meta has ever gone when it comes to child safety, critics and children’s advocates cautioned it will not solve its myriad problems overnight. Arturo Bejar, a former Meta



Colorado Solicitor General Shannon Stevenson hugs a colleague outside of court after tech giant Meta reached a settlement to end a landmark trial over teen social media addiction in Oakland, Calif. AP

engineering director, said the settlement is a “significant milestone,” but parents should not see Instagram as suddenly safe for children. “The agreement has a big problem in that it allows Meta to define harm,” Bejar said in an interview

Wednesday. “It’s one thing to say, Yeah, you only get like two hours of alcohol or two hours of cigarettes a day,” but it’s still as bad for you because of what’s getting delivered.” Bejar, the first witness to testify during the federal trial cut short by the settlement,

would like to see Meta address the effect of content recommendations to teens, which he says can prove addictive. While teens might put their phone down when they hit the two-hour limit, they can be distressed about it because the way the plat-

form is designed leaves them craving more.

Meta said people over 18 also can adopt versions of the new controls individually, such as daily time-limit reminders, but there will not be an option for them to opt into the overall settings for what teens experience on the platform.

Stronger age checks

To protect kids, first Meta has to know who they are. While the company has already been using artificial intelligence to determine if kids are lying about their age - either to sign up if they are under 13, which is not allowed, or to use adult accounts when they are 13 to 17 - it did not always work. Under the proposed settlement, Meta agreed to strengthen its technology to check kids’ ages, using its own as well as third-party tools, with regular outside audits on how well it is

working. The agreement also includes specific goals around false positive rates - that is, minors who are identified as over 18. And if a user is identified as under 13 and kicked off the platforms, Meta will check the ages of their friends, too.

“The age assurance section is reasonably good because it has measurement, has independent testing, has goals,” Bejar said. “Because I think Meta should be measured on effectiveness, not effort.” Meta requires users to be at least 13 years old to create an account, in line with federal child privacy law. In his testimony last week, Bejar said Meta took a “don’t ask, don’t tell” approach on kids under 13 on its platforms. “Meta has one of the most sophisticated infrastructures in the world to detect fake accounts,” he said. But despite that, he added, there were “no goals, no metrics” to detect and

check kids’ ages who were suspected to be under 13.

Some safety features will be on by default

Critics have faulted Meta over many of its safety features that users have to manually turn on, or opt into themselves. Of the host of safeguards listed in the settlement, many are on as a default. This includes the two-hour time limit, which can only be turned off with a parent’s permission, as well as the night mode that blocks use between midnight and 6 am.

Still, under the agreement other features, such as turning off video autoplay or showing posts in chronological order rather than having algorithms decide what to show kids scrolling through their feeds, will be opt-in.

Josh Golin, executive director of online safety nonprofit Fairplay, said the deal appeared to be too focused

on offering tools to parents rather than restricting harmful features altogether. “We are disappointed that the settlement does not turn off by default recommendation algorithms that connect kids to predators and send young people down dangerous rabbit holes,” Golin said.

Questions around default settings came up at the trial earlier this week when a lawyer for the states suing Meta pressed Adam Mosseri, the head of Instagram, on the low adoption rate among teens for the “take a break” feature, which prompts users to step away if they have been scrolling a while.

Very few teens used the feature when Instagram first introduced it, but since launching separate teen accounts in 2024, Meta has made it the default setting for teenage users. Still, if a teen didn’t want to take a break, they could simply swipe away the notification.

ICE officer charged in Minneapolis shooting released from Texas jail

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Brownsville

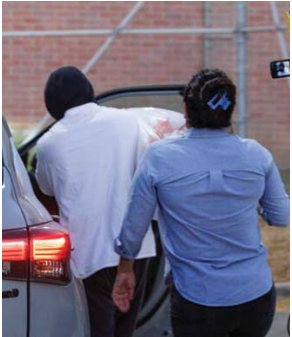
An Immigration and Customs Enforcement officer charged with shooting a man and lying about it during the immigration crackdown in Minneapolis was released from a Texas jail on Thursday, after a judge refused to order his return to Minnesota.

Christian Castro was released at the break of dawn from a detention centre in Brownsville. He motioned his hand toward a few camera operators and a reporter crowding around him and quickly got into an SUV that drove off.

A day earlier, US District Judge Fernando Rodriguez Jr. wrote in an order that said he couldn’t prevent a county sheriff from releasing Castro or order Texas Governor Greg Abbott to sign his extradition warrant. Castro is charged in Minnesota with assault and falsely reporting a crime in the January 14 shooting of 24-year-old Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis. Castro is accused of firing a gun through the front door of a Minneapolis home, shooting Sosa-Celis in the leg. Prosecutors say Castro also falsely accused Sosa-Celis and another man of attacking an ICE officer with a broom handle and a snow shovel.

After a Minnesota judge issued a nationwide warrant for Castro’s arrest in May, authorities, including Minnesota’s Bureau of Criminal Apprehension, arrested Castro in Cameron County on May 29. Minnesota authorities have sought his extradition since his arrest, but he remained in custody in Brownsville, a city bordering Mexico.

Under Texas law and barring extradition, Castro had to be released after 90 days of detention, which was Thursday. Minnesota officials believe Castro could flee to Mexico. Minnesota Attorney General Keith Ellison filed a request for a temporary restraining order last



week seeking to block Castro’s release or to order his return to Minnesota.

Texas attorneys on Tuesday argued the judge could not rule on a decision that’s still pending. Abbott has not denied the extradition. Instead he is waiting for the outcome of an internal state investigation considering whether Castro was legally a “fugitive” under the Extradition Clause, the lawyers said.

The judge wrote in Wednesday’s order that the court couldn’t yet step in. “The Court concludes that it lacks subject matter jurisdiction because the case is not ripe for adjudication,” the order read. “Minnesota cannot premise its causes of action on the allegation that Governor Abbott may violate those authorities in the future; it must prove that a violation has already occurred.” The judge said in his order that the extradition laws do not outline how long the Texas governor can take to make that decision.

Abbott said last week he would not respond to the extradition request, citing the ongoing investigation into fraud in Government social service programmes in Minnesota, which President Donald Trump used to justify his immigration crackdown there.

After the judge’s decision, Ellison posted online that the Texas governor had an obligation to extradite Castro. And by refusing to extradite him, “Greg Abbott is turning Texas into a sanctuary state for violent criminals.”

Russia bombards Ukrainian cities in escalated night strikes

HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv

Russia bombarded cities across Ukraine with missiles and drones in an onslaught that began after nightfall Wednesday and continued into daylight hours Thursday, when explosions echoed around the Capital Kyiv through the morning.

Ukraine is desperately short of US-made Patriot air defence missiles that can counter Russia’s ballistic missiles, and Moscow’s fast-flying jet-powered drones have brought another challenge in the fifth year since the Russian army’s invasion. Ukrainian officials say Russia

builds up missile stocks and launches major attacks every few days, hoping to exhaust Ukrainian defences through the sheer weight of numbers.

In response, Ukraine has hit high-profile targets on Russian soil as the countries inflict mutual destruction.

The Russian Defence Ministry said its forces carried out a “massive” overnight strike on targets in nine Ukrainian cities. It described the targets as military-related, including industrial facilities, oil refineries, logistics hubs and port infrastructure. Civilian areas including apartment blocks suffered damage. The barrage killed



Ukrainian President meets US lawmakers to outline war strategy

LISA MASCARO ■ Washington

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy arrived at the US Capitol hours after Lindsey Graham’s funeral to an unusually attentive audience.

Half the Senate gathered for the closed-door meeting. Senators set their mobile phones down and focused their attention. Along with representatives from the House, they listened as Zelenskyy fielded questions about his country’s strategy in the long war against Russia.

Zelenskyy told them how Ukraine was repelling the Russian invasion, taking the fight to Moscow, but in need of US help with Patriot interceptor missiles and licensing agreements, expanded access to Elon Musk’s Starlink internet - and most immediately ahead of a Senate vote that July night — a punishing Russia sanctions package to deprive President Vladimir Putin of the oil and gas revenue fueling the war machine. “He said, We need this legislation,” recalled Sen. Jeanne Shaheen, the top Democrat on the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, in an inter-



view. “Both the troops and the Ukrainian people need this for morale.”

“You could feel palpably in the room a sense that — Zelenskyy’s confidence of their ability to hold and to persevere,” said Rep Steny Hoyer of Maryland, a former Democratic leader. “There was a sense in the room that, look, we can be successful.” The massive Russian sanctions package from the late Sen Graham represented the most ambitious effort to support Ukraine since President Donald Trump returned to the White House. After two years of legislative inaction, it would be one of the

few moves from Congress since lawmakers sent supplemental aid funding to Ukraine in 2024.

Zelenskyy first appeared on a private video call with lawmakers in March 2022, days after the start of the war, when he urged the US to send planes to help Ukraine defend its skies from the Russian bombardment.

That winter, Zelenskyy delivered a dramatic Christmas-time address to Congress, giving thanks to “every American” in a speech evocative of British Prime Minister Winston Churchill’s own visit during World War II. (AP)

China urges US to overcome obstacles ahead of President Xi-Trump summit

HUIZHONG WU ■ Bangkok

China’s foreign minister said his country and the United States should overcome obstacles between the Nations ahead of an expected summit next month between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping.

Wang Yi met with US ambassador to China David Perdue on Wednesday and called on both sides to “focus on the positive agenda, properly manage differences, remove interference and overcome obstacles to high-level exchanges between the two countries,” Chinese state broadcaster CCTV reported on Thursday.

China-US relations “still face various risks and challenges,” he acknowledged in a statement released by CCTV. Trump and Xi met in May in Beijing and pledged to keep the relationship stable



China foreign minister Wang Yi

and maintain the fragile trade truce.

Trump invited Xi to meet Sept. 24 in the US but the exact date of the Chinese leader’s visit has not been confirmed. Since then, however, the US and China

have continued to take targeted economic action against each other including the US banning Chinese-made robots and China banning American entities engaging in trade and other activities in China. (AP)

Pakistan, Kuwait sign agreement to enhance defence cooperation

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan and Kuwait on Thursday signed an agreement to further strengthen bilateral defence cooperation, including in areas such as training, capacity building and border management.

The ‘Protocol Agreement-2026’ was signed during a meeting between Defence Minister Khawaja Asif and a high-level Kuwaiti delegation led by Defence Minister Sheikh Abdullah Ali Al-Sabah at the Ministry of Defence in Rawalpindi. The delegation was accompanied by Kuwait Chief of General Staff of the Armed Forces Lt Gen Khalid Al-Shriaan. According to an official statement, the two sides discussed matters of



Defence Minister Khawaja Asif

mutual interest, with particular focus on bilateral defence relations, security cooperation and further strengthening defence ties.

The new agreement significantly enhances the existing military cooperation framework established under the ‘Defence Cooperation Agreement-2023’, it said.

“Under the new agreement, the Armed Forces of Pakistan will extend assis-

tance to the Armed Forces of Kuwait in diverse fields, including training, capacity building, border management and other mutually agreed areas of defence collaboration,” it said.

The agreement reflects the deep trust, mutual respect and shared strategic interests underpinning the longstanding defence relationship between the two brotherly countries, the statement said. The Pakistan Army, in a separate statement, said the Kuwaiti delegation also met Field Marshal Asim Munir at the General Headquarters (GHQ) in Rawalpindi. The meeting focused on matters of mutual interest, regional security and bilateral defence cooperation. (PTI)

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA, MINISTRY OF CULTURE
ARCHAEOLOGICAL SURVEY OF INDIA
Office of Superintending Archaeologist,
22 Mall Road, Agra Circle, Agra. (UP)

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Applications are invited for engagement of a Legal Consultant on contract basis in the Office of Superintending Archaeologist, 22 Mall Road, Agra Circle, Agra & Meerut Circle, Meerut. (UP). Application in all respect must reach within 20 days from the dated of advertisement.
Essential Eligibility Conditions:-
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Age: He/She must be below the age of 65 years on the date of advertisement for this post.
Experience: Possesses at least ten (10) years experience in handling court cases related to administrative matters in Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) or High Courts/Supreme Courts and on labour related issues in CGIT on continuous basis. The candidate should be proficient in working on MS word and other computer applications. Knowledge of English & Hindi drafting is mandatory
Desirable: Candidate having experience in working in a Government/Autonomous organizations/PSUs will be preferred.
For detailed advertisement, eligibility criteria, terms & conditions, remuneration and application format, visit: www.asiagraccircle.in.
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NORTHERN RAILWAY
(E-Auction Notice)
Sr.Divisional Commercial Manager/PS, Northern Railway Delhi Division invites bids through e-Auction through IREPS (<http://ireps.gov.in>) for the allotment of Automated Teller Machine/Digital Banking Unit/Banking e-Lobby Contracts, at following Railway stations/locations:-

E-Catalogue No	Date & Time of bidding	Railway Stations/Locations/Sites
DLI-ATM-04-2026	15.09.2026 at 12.00 Hrs	Anand Vihar Terminal (2), Tohana (1), Jakhal (1), Noli (1),
Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen		https://ireps.gov.in/
All bidders who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids: - Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing Module -Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module -Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details A New mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism. The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in state bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account which enables them to participate in IREPS E-auctions. - Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors/Contractors (E-Tender/E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.		
Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query	Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055. Email: publicitycellndli@gmail.com Tel: 011-23743084	

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PROSPECT

Patna Mind Fest ends; winners receive cash prizes



The two-day Patna Mind Fest (PMF) 2026 concluded on Thursday with winners taking away prizes and certificates in five events judged across three categories each – open, college, and school. The events included India quiz, general quiz, creative writing (in Hindi and English), cryptic crosswords, and word bee. The 8th edition of this annual event was conducted at the Chandragupt Institute of Management Patna (CIMP). It is organised by the Bihar IAS Officers' Association in partnership with extra-c, a civil society initiative at the forefront of promoting knowledge-based co-curricular activities. The objective is to showcase the intellectual legacy of the state and sustain it by holding regular events. The prizes and certificates were handed over to the winners by chief guests Harjot Kaur, president, Bihar IAS Association, and Girish Shankar, chief election officer. Also present on the occasion were Vivek Kumar Singh, Chairman, RERA Bihar; Rachana Patil, IAS, secretary, Department of Finance, Bihar; and Shreshtha Anupam, IAS, joint secretary, Department of Finance, Bihar.

On the final day of the event, Shreyas Sridhar won the first prize in the open category in creative writing (English). Abhinav Priyadarshi and Vidisha Garg came 2nd and 3rd, respectively. In Creative Writing (Hindi), Samrat Sameer won the 1st prize. Suman Kumar and Ranjana Kumari were 2nd and 3rd, respectively. In the word bee open category, the team of Gokul and Calvin won the first spot. While the team comprising Shashank, Tayaganthan, and Samanway won the 2nd prize, that of Saransh, Samiran, and Subhadeep won the 3rd prize. In the cryptic crossword open category, Shradha Shree clinched the 1st spot. Soham Sarthak and Dhairya Pandey were in 2nd and 3rd spots, respectively. The college category saw Naman Bhaskar, Adya Singh, and Saumya Shiwangi in the first three spots, respectively. Shubhi Srivastava, Hemang Chandra, and Nanya Dev Singh clinched the first three spots in that order in the School Category.

Rahul's performative feminism vs Modi's grassroots transformation



SMITA MISHRA

Rahul Gandhi is being hailed as a path breaker by the entire Congress ecosystem ever since he gave a call to 'Smash Patriarchy' during an event organised for young women in Pune. This event was part of the Chhatron ki Goonj, loosely translated as 'echo of students' through which the Leader of Opposition has been trying to connect with the Gen Z. During the interaction, he exhorted young women to reject (what he called) the Manusmriti mindset of seeing women as Bahu, Beti, Behen that is belonging either to the father, son or husband. You belong to no one but yourself, he said emphatically.

All this sounds perfect when seen from the standpoint of a young woman who is raring to fulfill her dreams in life. It got Mr Gandhi the kind of social media attention such comments will always get. But once the charm of the reels subsides, one must think where does Rahul Gandhi or his party leaders actually stand on the issue themselves?

Let us take the Manusmriti argument first. Many critics are looking at his Bahu, Beti, Behen comment as an attempt to run down the Indian family system and bonds while some have fished out his old remarks where he was seen projecting his sister in an election rally. But I would welcome a leader exhorting women to carve their own



identity beyond family relations. The problem lies in Rahul Gandhi slamming Manusmriti and asking Hindu women to shun it while completely forgetting to mention that all religions and scriptures prescribe do's and don'ts which are not commensurate with today's society. He did not even notice that women in Hijab standing on the stage with him could have been given the same mantra. His singling out of Manusmriti gave detractors the opportunity to allege that Rahul's target was more on Hindu traditions than patriarchy per se.

But let us leave that for the women to judge. How has the Congress party, and the Gandhi family fared on this front? While Mr Gandhi finds Manusmriti's depiction problematic, he forgets that the biggest factor for a woman's dependent status is financial. His late father and former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi had a historic opportunity to make the lives of divorced Muslim women marginally better

when Supreme Court allowed a paltry maintenance amount to Shah Bano. Instead, Rajiv Gandhi chose to be on the wrong side of history by upturning the verdict in Parliament under pressure from fundamentalist elements who threatened to 'punish' Congress.

More recently, Congress chose to walk out from Lok Sabha during the passage of Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Marriage) or the Triple Talaq Bill.

Even today, one of the biggest states, Congress ruled Karnataka, does not have a single woman among its 33 cabinet ministers. Notably, Indira Gandhi, the daughter of Jawaharlal Nehru, became prime minister but no Congress government ever had a woman among the big four or the CCS. Many have also pointed out that the Nehru Gandhi family has always kept Priyanka Vadra a few steps behind her brother in case she steals the thunder from him. Even if that were to happen, it wouldn't quite

mean any real change because they are both there by virtue of their bloodline.

Narendra Modi, whom Rahul Gandhi has been challenging politically for over twelve years now, has presented a different model altogether. Having his roots in a humble, poor Hindu family with limited means, Narendra Modi has had a much closer, first hand view of women's position in the society. Introducing his first path breaking initiative, Swachh Bharat, he focused on building toilets. Rahul Gandhi could perhaps ask his seniors in the party why barely forty percent women had access to something as basic as toilets till 2014? How does a woman smash patriarchy when she has to wait for darkness to relieve herself? Modi also understood that the power balance in families would not shift until women had some financial 'heft' in their name.

Bank accounts through Jan Dhan scheme, ensuring PM Awas Yojana houses were registered in the name of the woman, providing easy, collateral free loans through MUDRA, announcing a slew of maternity benefits so that young mothers did not suffer professional loss and a phenomenal push to self help group through various incentives in order to economically empower women at the grassroots level..... these are measures which have changed the power dynamics of families in rural areas in a way that was unthinkable some years ago.

This author is witness to the remarkable surge in self confidence of young women in the remotest corners of the country.

They no longer follow the menfolk. They have access to phones and internet data. They are informed and prefer to form their own opinions on current political and social issues. Their awareness level is far higher and they are keen to chart their own course.

Today, there is a bigger number of women aspirants compared to men raring to fight the local body/ Panchayat elections in villages which were considered extremely backward till recently.

One can refer to all the data related to these schemes and many others. The crux of the matter is women cannot smash patriarchy by simply wishing it away. Enabling legal structures, financial agency, professional opportunities and political platforms are essential to make it possible.

Catchy one-liners like the one made by Rahul Gandhi are good headline material and attractive content for a generation which spends a good amount of time on social media. But these one-liners must also be substantiated with solid ground work. Seen from that perspective, Rahul Gandhi and Congress party's record pales.

To smash patriarchy he could make a beginning by inducting a woman or two as minister in Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh. He could have admonished his colleague Sandeep Dikshit who recently made a crass, sexist comment on the Prime Minister of Italy in an open party event. Instead Rahul Gandhi chose to enjoy the 'joke'. He missed the bus there too.

The author is a journalist. She writes on politics, security and current issues

GMDA intensifies enforcement drive across city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) has intensified its enforcement action against encroachments across Gurugram, with a continued focus on keeping roads and public spaces free from unauthorised occupation. Chief Executive Officer, GMDA, PC Meena has directed the enforcement teams to maintain sustained action against encroachments and ensure that areas freed from encroachment remain free from re-encroachment.

The latest enforcement drive, led by DTP GMDA RS Bath on Thursday, addressed



around 15 kilometres of road stretches across various parts of Gurugram. Multiple enforcement teams were deployed at different locations to undertake action against encroachments and

restore public spaces for their intended use.

On the Basai Road (9B/10) and Sector 37C/10 stretches, covering around 3 kilometres, action was taken against several types of encroach-

ments. Approximately 65 tin sheds, ramps and 10 carts were removed from the Basai Road stretch. On the combined stretches of Sector 37C/9B, Sector 37C/37D and Sector 37D/9B, around 3.7 kilometres of road were taken up for enforcement action.

The enforcement drive was further extended to the Sector 102/102A stretch, where around 1.5 kilometres were addressed, and approximately 20 carts and three nursery-related encroachments were removed.

PC Meena said that GMDA will continue its strict enforcement action against unauthorised encroachments across the city.

HDFC Bank mulling appeal against NCLT ruling in Subhash Chandra case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Leading private lender HDFC Bank is mulling an appeal against the bankruptcy court NCLT's order in the case involving Subhash Chandra, the bank said on Thursday.

The bank said only 3.2 per cent of the total claim amount has been admitted under the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order in the matter. HDFC Bank's total claim was ₹680 crore.

"HDFC Bank had opposed and voted against this resolution, which was approved by the majority. The Bank is exploring filing an appeal at the NCLAT (National Company Law Appellate Tribunal)," HDFC Bank said in a statement.

HDFC Bank said it had inherited the loan facility from its parent, HDFC, before the bank's merger.

The bank's response comes a day after an NCLT ruling in the matter triggered controversy, as lenders had to take steep haircuts and are seen to be getting a negligible sum against their claims.

In an order on Wednesday, the NCLT approved a repayment plan



under which media baron Chandra will pay just ₹6.5 crore to settle admitted creditor claims of over ₹22,000 crore, resulting in a haircut of 99.97 per cent for lenders.

NCLT Member (Judicial) Nitesh Sharma, ruling as a third member, on Tuesday approved the plan under Section 114 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), rejecting objections by lenders that the recovery was too meagre to merit approval.

The matter stems from the default of an entity called Vivek Infracon on a ₹170 crore loan taken by the then Indiabulls Housing Finance, which turned sour.

Chandra had given a personal guarantee on the

loan and the lender's move to NCLT to kickstart bankruptcy proceedings led to claims of over ₹22,000 crore from peers who also owed money.

Two members of the National Company Law Tribunal had given a split verdict, after which the president of the forum appointed member (judicial) Nitesh Sharma as the third member amid the difference of opinion.

Sharma rejected the claims of the dissenting creditors led by LIC Housing Finance, which had argued that the payout was "unviable and unlawful." It had contended that against admitted claims of approximately ₹22,006.57 crore, the

repayment plan proposed the payment of only ₹6.25 crore to creditors and ₹25 lakhs towards process costs.

Sharma, in its 144-page-long order, said the resolution professional's valuation showed Chandra's personal estate was worth significantly less than the amount offered under the plan, and that dissenting creditors were unlikely to recover more by rejecting it, since he would then face bankruptcy rather than being able to pay from a position of financial recovery.

"If the plan is approved and the debtor's insolvency is resolved, putting him back on his feet, the objectors would ultimately stand a better chance of recovering their debts directly from the Principal Debtors," the NCLT observed.

The tribunal held that its role was not to substitute its own commercial wisdom for that of the creditors or to assess whether the settlement amount was adequate.

It also noted that "the commercial decision of the creditors operates within, and not outside, the statutory framework".

DAILY SUDOKU

7

1 3

2 4

2

1 9

6 7

4

8 4

2

5

9 2

1

3 4

9

6

8

1 6

4 2

4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (27.8.26)

7	3	9	6	4	2	8	5	1
1	8	6	7	5	9	3	2	4
2	4	5	3	8	1	7	6	9
3	9	2	8	6	7	1	4	5
6	1	7	5	9	4	2	3	8
8	5	4	2	1	3	9	7	6
9	6	3	1	2	5	4	8	7
4	7	8	9	3	6	5	1	2
5	2	1	4	7	8	6	9	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | AUGUST 28, 2026

ACROSS

8 Argued the cricketer must be seen in action (7)
9 When you're being formal, do (9)
13 Turn the small mug round (5)
14 Am to blame for bringing back from N. Italy (5)
15 Make up for having overcharged? (7)
16 Say to the chaps to turn it over (7)
17 Cets level with and produces the gun (5)
18 The police break it open (5)
20 A bit quiet; embarrassed (5)
22 Give way and shut up (6)
23 To show in, I even produced a key (6)
25 Old soldier his superior officers discharge? (7)
27 Don't stop to make a fuss about (5,2)

DOWN

1 Get out of calling (6)
2 It was shivering in the end. That's what made it cold (4,4)
3 Not revealing that one's slowing the progress of (7,4)
4 Book in a restaurant that's accessible (3-2-4)
5 Are rearranging the roster - he's not imagining it (7)
6 What makes you so hot on acting? (5,5)
7 Thunder "Run away!" (4)
10 Gets out the remnants left standing (6)
11 Make a coloured holster for the gun (7)
12 That blessed thing! (6)

SOLUTION (27.8.26)

4, Du-ties	21, P-articles	DOWN	18, Art-Hur
7, Victoria	23, Car-t	1, E-Vict	20, Gem-ma
8, Tri-MPS	24, Pa-LM	2, Actor	21, Pa-y
10, Co-O-OK	26, Boy	3, Work	22, Gad
13, Je-er	27, H-O-e'd	4, Dates	23, Go-gen't
14, Tars	29, Moo-D	5, To-Ur	25, D-og
15, Bust	32, Pu-rr	6, Expand	28, Order
16, Gnu	33, Barge	11, Raw	30, Orbit
17, Co-f-n	34, Record	12, O-scar	31, Deal't
19, Egad	35, Edge-hill	13, Juniper	32, Park
	36, Stoker	15, Bit	33, Bees
		16, Gas	

Swiggy expands food on train service to 201 stations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Swiggy on Thursday said its Food on Train service has currently expanded to 201 railway stations from 66 stations in 2024.

The Food on Train network now includes Kolhapur, Wardha, Shahdol, Kakinada, Bharatpur, Chittoor, Thanjavur, Raigarh, Jamnagar, Indore and Tundla stations, among others, Swiggy said.

Sidharth Bhakoo, Chief Business Officer, Swiggy Food Marketplace, said, "Food on Train has seen multifold growth since its launch in March 2024 and has witnessed widespread adoption across various consumer cohorts, including Gen Z. We are also seeing a huge opportunity for our affordability offerings."

The online food delivery firm also shared interesting trends around the evolving food habits of train travellers. In just over a year, passengers have switched from fast food

and carbonated drinks to healthier, refreshing options, it stated.

Compared to last year, travellers are preferring traditional and refreshing drinks like lassi (up 60 per cent), buttermilk (up 40 per cent), and mojitos (up 90 per cent), while orders for standard fizzy drinks have dropped considerably. ?

Moreover, the Food on Train service is seeing a return to traditional and regional comfort foods, with full meals like Thalis comprising over 65 per cent of all train orders.

Additionally, orders for sweets have more than doubled, led by rasgullas.

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund raises stake in SBI Card to 7.3%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund has increased its stake in SBI Card to 7.3 per cent by acquiring additional shares from the open market, the credit card firm said on Thursday. The fund house has carried out the acquisition of 21,60,916 shares on August 25 through the open market, SBI Card said in a regulatory filing.

As a result, the shareholding of the fund house has increased by 2.12 per cent from the earlier level of 5.18 per cent, the credit card subsidiary of SBI added. With the acquisition, total sharehold-

ing in the card company rose to 7.3 per cent.

US firm GE was the initial promoter of SBI Credit Card when launched in 1998. There were criticism on State Bank of India, allowing US firm GE to sell its credit cards. GE exited in 2017 and another multinational company Carlyle Group ventured with SBI in prmoting credit card.

DIRECTORATE
Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board

Mandi Bhawan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph:05944-250056 Fax: 05944-30059

Ref: U.K.A.P.M.B./2026/1407 Date: 27.08.2026

Public Information

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is Inviting Auction of land & Floriculture Mandi in Bhurarani Rudrapur and to be given on lease rent.

Applying process and other related information and conditions may be seen on <https://www.procfcof.com> from 29.08.2026 on 12:00 noon to 15.09.2026 till 5:00 pm.

Interested persons and firms may visit at <https://www.procfcof.com> for further necessary action.

General Manager (Finance)

BRIEFLY

Divya to make Global Chess League debut with Alpine Pipers



Indian chess star Divya Deshmukh will make her Tech Mahindra Global Chess League debut with defending champions Alpine Pipers when the fourth season begins here on September 5. The 20-year-old, who recently won an Arjuna Award, will join a formidable Pipers' line-up featuring world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen, Anish Giri, Vidit Gujrathi and Volodar Murzin. Having largely competed in individual tournaments, Deshmukh said she is looking forward to the challenge of rapid chess in the league's franchise-based team format and the opportunity to play in front of a home crowd. "It's my debut, so I'm definitely very excited. It's not like any other chess tournament. There's going to be a lot of audience for this one, which is going to be really nice. And also, the format is quite different to classical events, so it's fun. Playing in India is always fun," Deshmukh said. While the opportunity to play alongside Carlsen has added to the anticipation surrounding her debut, Deshmukh said the overall strength of the squad was equally exciting. "I guess it's always great to have a teammate that is considered one of the best in the world. But for me, it's also not just Magnus in my team. There are so many great players overall. There's Anish, there's Vidit, and there's also Murzin. So, it's not just about one person. It's about the whole team," she added. (PTI)

Barcelona signs Croatia's Livakovic from Fenerbahce



Barcelona has signed Croatia goalkeeper Dominik Livakovic from Turkish club Fenerbahce. Barcelona said Thursday that the 31-year-old Livakovic signed a contract until 2030. Livakovic is set to play a reserve role in a squad that already has Joan Garcia — the team's regular starter — and veteran Wojciech Szczesny. Barcelona earlier this month sent Germany goalkeeper Marc-Andre ter Stegen to Ajax on a loan. Financial details of the Livakovic transfer were not immediately available. Livakovic started at NK Zagreb in the Croatian first division before joining Dinamo Zagreb for the 2016-17 season. After seven seasons he signed with Fenerbahce, where he stayed two years before joining Spanish club Girona on a loan. Livakovic returned to Dinamo Zagreb this year, also on loan, after being criticized by Girona coach Michel for not prioritizing the club. Michel said the reserve goalkeeper refused to play in a match and wanted to leave the club. He said the goalkeeper was only worried about the World Cup. Livakovic has been a regular in the Croatia squad since 2017, having played in the last three World Cups and the last two European Championships. (AP)

Marathon world record holder Sabastian Sawe injured and out of comeback run in Berlin

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Berlin

Marathon world record holder Sabastian Sawe says he is injured and will miss the Berlin Marathon, which was set to mark his return to competition after smashing the two-hour barrier.

Sawe said he had been targeting "something special" next month in Berlin. He won the event last year and it is one of the fastest marathon courses in the world, the site of numerous records.

"It is with a heavy heart that I must inform you I am forced to withdraw from the BMW Berlin Marathon due to an injury," Sawe said in a statement issued by organizers. He didn't specify what



sort of injury he had.

"I had been looking forward to achieving something special on the streets of Berlin and crossing the finish line at the Brandenburg Gate," He added: "I want to thank everyone who continues to support me and I wish

Women's hockey team beats Germany to finish fifth in WC

MONA PARTHASARATHI
■ Amstelveen

The Indian women's hockey team pulled off a dominant 3-1 win over higher-ranked Germany in a classification match to finish a creditable fifth in the FIH World Cup, its best show in 52 years, here on Thursday. Navneet Kaur (44th and 47th) scored a brace to play a major role in the win as India ended their campaign on a high. Ishika (43rd minute) was the other goal getter for India. Lynn Krings pulled one back for Germany in the 59th minute.

This was the Indian women team's best performance since finishing fourth in the inaugural World Cup in 1974 under

Ajinder Kaur's leadership. The current Indian team has 11 World Cup debutants, and the fifth place finish makes it more noteworthy.

Ninth-ranked India suffered just one defeat in the whole tournament — at the hands of Olympic champions and hosts the Netherlands (0-2). This performance will undoubtedly boost the Indian team's confidence ahead of next month's Asian Games.

The Indian team, which held Olympic silver medalist China to a 2-2 draw in the opening match, defeated South Africa 6-1 but then drew with England. Having eliminated from the semi-final race after a goal-less draw against Australia in the final match of



the second round, India pulled out all the stops against Germany, scoring three goals in the final 17 minutes.

Coach Sjoerd Marijne, who had guided India to a historic fourth place finish in Tokyo

Olympics, jumped with joy after the final hooter.

This same German team had defeated India in two practice matches before the tournament. However in the fifth-place classification match

India has progressed in both men and women's game: Dutch Hockey CEO Eric Gerritsen

MONA PARTHASARATHI
■ Amstelveen

Royal Dutch Hockey Association (KNHB) CEO Eric Gerritsen believes India's sustained investment in the game has brought the country back to where it belonged on the international stage, but the reigning Olympic bronze medalist needs to more focus on the World Cup to finish on the podium. He also revealed that India's passion and hosting of World Cups influenced the Dutch approach in the ongoing edition.

"I think India has progressed in both men and women immensely over the



past decade. And that has to do with those investments and with sustainable investments which last through years. That's why they are back on the international stage where they should be," Gerritsen said.

India's men's team has won bronze at the last two

Olympics while the women's side finished fourth in Tokyo, but the country continues to wait for a World Cup medal. Gerritsen, who has attended the 2018 and 2023 World Cups in Bhuvanesar and Rourkela, feels India's simultaneous focus on the World Cup and the Asian Games make the task more difficult. "What's maybe a little bit difficult for India in the World Cup is that this year India, both men and women, focus on both the World Cup but also the Asian Games which are coming up," he said. "If the focus of India could be not 99 per cent but 120 per cent on the World Cup, the medals

could have come." Gerritsen believes as many as eight teams could realistically challenge for the men's title, including India, Australia and Argentina alongside five European sides. He said he had closely observed the last two World Cups in India, including the fan engagement and opening ceremony. "Those stadiums were even a little bit bigger than ours, so we've really learned from them. I still remember the huge opening ceremony. We learned from that and the passion in India. We tried to copy certain things of that and adapt it to our own style," he said. (PTI)

India to host Uruguay in friendly on October 6 in Kolkata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India will host two-time World Cup champions Uruguay for a football friendly on October 6 in Kolkata, the third international match the country will play at home against quality teams in the upcoming FIFA window.

The match will be played three days after India's international friendly against five-time World Cup champions Brazil at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan in Kolkata. The match against Uruguay will also be played at the same iconic venue.

The Indian team is also playing against Panama at the Kanteerava Stadium in Bengaluru on September 26.

The FIFA international window is from September



21 to October 6 and a country can play a maximum of four matches in this period.

"The Indian men's national team will welcome another heavyweight of world football to Kolkata, with two-time FIFA World Cup champions Uruguay set to face India in an international friendly match at

Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan on October 6, 2026. The fixture will be India's third high-profile international friendly of the window," the All India Football Federation (AIFF) said in a statement on Thursday.

"La Celeste's arrival in Kolkata adds another major

fixture to an unprecedented run of international football for Indian fans, with three World Cup-playing nations — Panama, Brazil and Uruguay — set to visit the country within the same FIFA window." Uruguay are currently ranked 20th in the FIFA chart. They won the World Cup in 2030 and 1950, and reached the semifinals three times — 1954, 1970 and 2010.

In the 2026 World Cup, they made a group stage exit, after playing out draws against Saudi Arabia (1-1) and Cape Verde (2-2), and losing to eventual champions Spain (0-1).

They were also eliminated in the group stage in the 2022 World Cup. The current head coach of Uruguay, Diego Forlan, played for Mumbai City FC in 2016.

India's racing sensation Atiqa Mir gets a boost from JK Tyre

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi,

JK Tyre, longtime supporters of Indian motorsport, on Thursday signed 11-year-old racing sensation Atiqa Mir, reinforcing its long-standing commitment to invest in future champions.

At such a young age, Atiqa has already made a strong mark on the international karting circuit, winning races in Europe and beating world class drivers older than her.

Atiqa, the first Indian to be supported by the F1 Academy, is currently competing in different series in Europe and is the highest ranked female in FIA's International Karting Ranking in the OKN1 category (age 12-14). She joins an



elite list of accomplished Indian drivers to be supported by JK Tyre, following in the footsteps of Narain Karthikeyan and Karun Chandhok, the only two Indians who have reached

the pinnacle of F1.

Earlier this year, she became the first Indian to secure a podium in the European leg of the Champions of the Future Academy, before going on to

deliver a dominant victory in Greece, where she became only the third driver in the series' history to sweep qualifying, heats and the final.

More recently, Atiqa added another feather to her cap by becoming the youngest Indian to record two top 10 finishes in FIA European Karting Championship which is considered the 'Formula 1 of Karting.'

Her journey also represents the growing presence of women in motorsport. Atiqa was the first Indian and Asian female racer selected for F1 Academy's Discover Your Drive programme, further underlining her position as one of the sport's emerging young talents.

"It is a very special feeling to join JK Tyre. My dad (Asif

Mir who was India's first national karting champion) was also supported by JK Tyre during his racing days.

"I have always admired the company's contribution to Indian motorsport and the opportunities it has created for young racers. I'm excited for this journey and look forward to learning, improving and representing India and JK Tyre on the international stage," said Atiqa. Anshuman Singhania, Managing Director, JK Tyre & Industries, said the tyre major was happy to support Atiqa in her fast rising career.

"Atiqa represents the next generation of Indian racing, and we are delighted to support her as she pursues excellence on the global stage," said Singhania.

GCT grand finale: Praggnanandhaa lets Fabiano Caruana off the hook



9 for Pragg and still not all is over for him if he can make a comeback in the rapid and blitz games that follow.

In the fight for third place, Wesley So drew with

Vincent Keymer and the scores are level here with six points apiece for both participants. The third-place finisher will get direct entry in the next year's tour besides the top two.

After doing everything right from an Italian opening, Pragg slipped on the 55th turn when he just had a position that would have led to equal points. Once he missed, Caruana was spot on to find the balance he always wanted. After two Classical games, now two Rapid games worth four points each will be played followed by four Blitz games worth two points each.

Champions League draw to be held at gathering of European soccer elite

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Monaco

The Champions League draw will be held on Thursday during a gathering of European soccer leaders who also have off-field politics also on their minds.

Two hours before the gala draw ceremony starts at 6 pm local time (1600 GMT) in Monaco, most of UEFA's 55 member federations will meet to discuss the governance crisis provoked by FIFA President Gianni Infantino's failed attempt to sell stakes in World Cup profits to private investors.

Chaired by UEFA president Aleksander Ceferin, it will be their first face-to-face meeting since the month-



long turmoil started in global soccer. Infantino is not expected in Monaco, where he used to host the Champions League draw when he served as UEFA's general secretary until being elected in 2016 to lead FIFA. Infantino is up for reelection

in March but UEFA has said it has no confidence in his leadership. Speculation on who might one day replace Infantino often lands on someone who will have a front row seat at the draw: the president of Champions League title holder Paris

Saint-Germain, Nasser al-Khelaifi. He has yet to declare an interest in running. PSG heads the 36-team Champions League lineup alongside a stellar group of contenders: record 15-time European champion Real Madrid, Bayern Munich, Barcelona and last season's finalist Arsenal. Four newcomers will debut in this Champions League edition: Como from Italy, coached by Cesc Fabregas; LASK of Austria; Viking from Norway; and Azerbaijani champion Sabah, which was founded only in 2017.

Sabah coach Valdas Dambrauskas is already making headlines for his curious origin story in soccer.

The money he won as a young contestant on TV quiz show "Who Wants to be a Millionaire" in his native Lithuania funded a trip to study coaching in England.

Another first this season is an African coach taking his team into the main phase. Former Manchester City and Barcelona star Yaya Toure guided Slovakian champion Slovan Bratislava through its qualifying playoff Wednesday. Also on the agenda in Monaco are meetings for the influential European Football Clubs group, UEFA's committee overseeing club competitions and a special session of most of UEFA's 55 member federations. (AP)

PM Modi urges youth to expand Olympic participation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A sports enthusiast, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Thursday, urged the youth to take up games quipping “Screens se zyada, Sports centres ki ahmiyat hai. Play station se zyada, Playgrounds ki ahmiyat hai”(Sports centres are more essential than screens and playgrounds are more essential than play stations.)

He also said his vision for sports is not merely about winning medals but making it an integral part of the nation-building process. PM Modi rued India's lack of participation in “half of the competitions on the Olympic

Games roster”, saying the country's medal tally can improve only if previously unrepresented events like surfing and sport climbing find contenders. The Prime Minister's remarks came days after he said receiving national sportspersons at his official residence here has been a regular and cherished tradition throughout his 12 to 13-year tenure.

Addressing hundreds of athletes, students and volunteers virtually on Thursday who gathered at various locations for the Khelo India Dialogue ahead of National Sports Day on Saturday, the Prime Minister said “In the Olympics, there are so many different sports... Indian

teams don't even participate in half of them, which means that we are not competing for a major chunk of the medal tally.” He called it a “bitter truth”.

“And this has been going on for decades. In 2012, we competed in only 13 sports. We were not even there in over 20 events and not many in the country even knew about some of these competitions. “Other countries win medals in those sports, and we don't even participate. To increase our medals, we have to improve in these sports,” he pointed out. In the 2024 Paris Olympics, India participated in 16 of the 32 sports which were on the Games roster.



However, no Indian has ever competed in the surfing and sport climbing competitions of the Olympic Games. Both these events are part of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics schedule.

“For example surfing and sport climbing...We have such

a vast coastline, we have such a vast hilly region where there could be a natural affinity for sports like these. from water sports to winter sports, we have the required demography as well as geography,” he asserted. “Despite this, we are not seen in these

sports anywhere in the world. That's why we have to find opportunities of growing these sports in different regions. To increase our medal tally, we will have to master these sports as well,” he added. In his Independence Day speech on August 15, Modi had announced a nationwide talent hunt for children in the age group of 5 to 15 to ensure that India's participation improves at the Olympics.

“On 15th August, I presented India's sports vision from the ramparts of the Red Fort. When I talk about sports... it is not merely about winning medals. “It is a campaign to integrate India's sporting power and youth power

together in the construction of a developed India,” he said. Describing sport as essential to building character in youngsters, Modi said it also has a massive role in ensuring that the youth stays away from the menace of drug abuse which has become a major challenge for the country. “Sports doesn't just teach us to become champions, it also teaches us to become better competitors. Rising, falling, and then rising again... Sports brings this spirit within us,” he said.

The Prime Minister also paid tributes to hockey wizard Major Dhyan Chand, whose birth anniversary is celebrated as the National Sports Day on August 29.

“In another two days, on August 29, there is National Sports Day...This day is also to remember Major Dhyan Chand. A 100 years ago, an Indian hockey team went on a tour of New Zealand, and in that team, Dhyan Chand was there...That tour is the foundation of the centenary celebration of India-New Zealand sporting ties,” he said. “Few days back when I went to New Zealand, I had remembered him.”

Drawing inspiration from Para-athletes, Modi said they are the prime example of how sport can change lives of not just individuals but also their families, their immediate surroundings and even their cities.

Centurion Dinusha's dogged effort helps SL draw second Test; India win series 1-0

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

Centurion Sonal Dinusha's unbending will en route an epic unbeaten 133 helped Sri Lanka enact a great jail break, battling persistent Indian bowlers, a fifth-day track and the weariness of following-on to eke out a memorable draw in second and final Test on Thursday. India won the two-match series 1-0, riding on their 165-run victory in the first Test at Galle, but Lanka can be proud of the way they fought back at SSC ground.

Dinusha, who faced 264 balls, was Lanka's Superman with an invisible cape around him, registering his third hundred of series which was also his fourth 50-plus score in as many innings this series.

Dinusha faced as many as

722 balls and batted 1139 minutes over the course of the two-match series.

The 25-year-old also became the only third batter to score twin hundreds in a Test match where his team followed-on, joining India's Vijay Hazare and Zimbabwe's Andy Flower in an elite club.

This statistical marvel enabled Lanka to end their second innings at 429 for nine declared for an overall lead of 216 runs, and at that point the players shook their hands, signalling the stalemate. But the situation was way different when Sri Lanka resumed the day at 229 for six, a mere 16 runs ahead.

It seemed just a matter of time before the home side caved in. But the opposite happened as the Indians bowed to the spirit of the Lankan batters — Dinusha,



who reached hundred in 196 balls, and Keshara Nuwantha (46, 150b). The two milked 112 runs for the seventh wicket in 246 balls, which saw Lanka safely treading the first session without even losing a wicket. But India enjoyed a rare moment of delight in the initial part of the post-lunch passage, as Manav Suthar dislodged Nuwantha, whose edge was taken safely by Dhruv Jurel in the slip.

Sri Lanka then mounted a mini fightback through Dinusha and Prabath Jayasuriya (2, 28b). The eighth wicket pair added only 25 runs but took 74 balls for it, pushing the clock further.

Ravindra Jadeja fetched another breakthrough as he jettisoned Jayasuriya, inducing an edge from the batter for Jurel in the second slip.

But they ran into another obdurate Lankan — Lahiru

Kumara, with whom Dinusha added 47 runs but consumed 170 balls to wipe out hopes of a victory from Indians' hearts.

Kumara fell to Jadeja, but Asitha Fernando (0 not out, 24 balls) stayed with Dinusha till the end, ensuring that draw was the only possible result. Dinusha was the chief catalyst of that eventuality. How this young cricketer, who is playing only his fifth Test, managed to rise above the situational pressure and cramping on his legs to bat the whole day will be a study material for several coaches and players in the years to come. There is this innate elegance to Dinusha's batting especially while driving and pulling.

But today he was ready to play ugly, trusting his defensive game. He smothered spinners' turn from the back foot and moved well behind

the ball against the quicker bowlers. The Indians tried gamely even in patches, employing short-pitch balls and down leg side delivery tactics to deprive Dinusha of strike, and get the late order batters in line against spinners. It worked reasonably but just that the likes of Nuwantha and Kumara did not indulge in the expected sloggling. They should be given truckload of credit for that. The tourists were also not helped by the fact that lead pacer Mohammad Siraj was not at his best.

Gill's captaincy too left a lot to be desired when the going was not smooth in the first session, and went to dressing room for a possible conversation with the coaching staff. But all that came to nothing, as Dinusha and the tailenders blunted the waves of attack. (PTI)

Pakistan reduces England to 80-4 at lunch as Abbas takes three at Lord's

FOSTER NIUMATA
■ London

Pakistan reduced England to 80-4 at lunch on the first morning of the Lord's test on Thursday. New ball bowler Mohammad Abbas removed the opening batters and captain Joe Root in the first hour but England's Jordan Cox survived to lunch as the hosts seek a series-clinching second win with a match to spare.

Heavy morning rain delayed the start for 80 minutes and returning Pakistan captain Babar Azam had no hesitation in muggy conditions forcing England to bat first on a green-tinged pitch. The decision paid off. In the fifth over, Emilio



Gay glanced Abbas down the leg side but wicketkeeper Mohammad Rizwan flung out his right glove in a dive and took a stunning catch.

Two overs later, the other opener, Ben Duckett, was out, leg before on 17 at 26-2. Pakistan had to overturn a not out decision to give Abbas his 900th first-class wicket. (AP)

India tour of New Zealand drives record early ticket sales

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Wellington

India's upcoming multi-format tour of New Zealand has driven record early demand, with 26,000 tickets sold in the first 48 hours of the host board's pre-sale.

The 12-match tour, beginning in October, has emerged as the biggest draw in New Zealand Cricket's Cricket Nation members' pre-sale, which went live on Monday.

The white-ball matches at Auckland's Eden Park have led the way in terms of tickets sold, while strong demand has also been reported from Christchurch and Wellington.

Hagley Oval, which has a capacity of 9,000, is expected to sell out for the first two T20 Internationals on October 22 and 24 as well as the second and final Test



from November 27 to December 1.

Early sales have also been strong for matches in Wellington, which will host the third T20I and second ODI, while the Basin Reserve will stage the opening Test from November 19.

New Zealand Cricket chief marketing and commercial officer Glenn Critchley said fans had responded to the call to secure tickets early.

“Our message to fans from the start has been to get organised to avoid missing out - and the record sales in

the first two days proves many have listened,” Critchley was quoted as saying by NZC.

“This is a rare chance for Kiwis to experience the incredible buzz of a game of cricket involving India and watch some of the biggest sport stars on the planet compete.

“We've deliberately kept the ticket prices the same as the previous season, and at under \$30 a ticket using our Cricket Nation access code,

“We're delighted fans are getting in early to secure their seats and with the general public sale still 11 days away, our message remains the same - get organised and don't miss out.” The general public sale will begin on September 7, but NZC said fans can access the pre-sale and receive a 15 per cent discount by signing up for Cricket Nation.

Pakistan may struggle to get bilateral series with top teams: Moin Khan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Former Test captain Moin Khan fears that Pakistan may struggle to arrange bilateral series with top teams in the world if the national team continues to perform poorly.

The wicketkeeper-batsman, who competed in 69 Tests and 219 ODIs for Pakistan, minced no words in blaming the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) and its selectors for the current state of affairs.

“We have been struggling in all formats but notably in test matches and if this trend continues I am afraid people will lose interest in Pakistan cricket,” Moin said on a podcast. “We might find ourselves relegated to the bottom half of the cricket world finding it difficult to get bilateral series with top teams. “I blame the frequent changes being made by the board in the cricket system including appointments/removal of captains, coaches, players and the inexplicable calls made by the national selectors.

“Unless you don't have continuity, stability and faith in a captain, coach or players, how can you expect to



achieve good results,” he said. Moin said in the last few years the frequent changes in domestic cricket and the national team had hit Pakistan cricket hard and players were losing confidence in the system.

Moin who earned a reputation as being a fighting cricketer and a man of crisis also noted that the PCB took decisions not as an institution but as per the personnel wishes of those who are in positions of power in the board at a given time. “Whenever a chairman and management team is changed you see things change in our cricket system which are not necessarily productive. So where is the stability?,” he asked. Moin also didn't spare the players and expressed disappointment at the attitude of some players.

“I don't want to harp on the past but to me it seems most players nowadays don't give enough time to developing their skills and cricket temperament. It is more about how much money we can make in leagues rather than setting and reaching personal goals of excellence as a cricketer.”

Moin said when a player was successful money followed automatically. “When I played we earned in lakhs. Nowadays players earn in crores but players must also remember nothing is greater than playing for your country with success.” (PTI)



भारत निर्वाचन आयोग
Election Commission of India



CHIEF ELECTORAL
OFFICER, HARYANA

SIR 2026

विशेष गहन पुनरीक्षण

हरियाणा

आपका मत, आपकी पहचान – हर संकल्प

फॉर्म-6

नए मतदाता के लिए

यदि आप 18 वर्ष की आयु पूर्ण कर चुके हैं और आपका नाम मतदाता सूची में नहीं है, तो फॉर्म-6 भरें।



नया नाम जोड़ने हेतु

फॉर्म-7

नाम हटाने के लिए

यदि कोई मतदाता स्थाई रूप से स्थानांतरित हो गया है, मृत्यु हो गई है या दोहराव (डुप्लीकेट) है, तो फॉर्म-7 भरें।



नाम हटाने हेतु

फॉर्म-8

विवरण सुधारने के लिए

यदि आपके नाम, आयु, पता, फोटो या अन्य विवरण में कोई गलती है, तो फॉर्म-8 भरें।



विवरण सुधारने हेतु

उपरोक्त फॉर्म 6 व 8 के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज एवं घोषणा-पत्र संलग्न करें।

फॉर्म के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा करने के विकल्प

 ऑनलाइन
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या

 अपने क्षेत्र के
ERO / AERO कार्यालय में
व्यक्तिगत रूप से

विशेष अभियान की तिथियां

 29-30 अगस्त, 2026

विशेष अभियान दिवस

सभी बी.एल.ओ. अपने-अपने मतदान केन्द्र पर प्रातः 9 बजे से सायं 5 बजे तक उपस्थित रहेंगे।

लोकतंत्र को बनाएं और मजबूत

 अधिक जानकारी के लिए
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